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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

PRESIDENT STRESSES DEVELOPMENT OF TOURISM

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Baglung, Dec. 27

President Ramchandra Paudel has said that the people's living standards should be raised by developing the tourism sector.

Speaking at the inauguration programme of the 7th Baglung Festival here on Wednesday, the President said, "We have beautiful natural tourist spots. The rural economy can be developed by bringing in tourists by building infrastructure and promoting touristic attractions with joint government and private sector initiatives."

President Paudel recalled the hard struggle days spent in Baglung during his political life and said that he has the responsibility to protect the achievements of people's sacrifices.

"No one can harm this constitution written by the people of Nepal," he said.

President Paudel expressed his belief that the festival would play an important role in the economic, social and cultural development and prosperity of the area around Baglung, which is rich in natural resources including the Dhaulagiri snow range and the fertile land.

The capital and experience of the private sector are needed for the development of this sector, he said, "The activation of the private sector is necessary to promote tourism while protecting and reviving rural life, special natural places, beautiful rural terrain, livelihood and ethnic costumes."

President Paudel said that the steps taken by businessmen for tourism promotion and development were exemplary.

He requested the private sector to increase investment as the development and prosperity of the region could be achieved by developing cultural, religious, sports and adventure tourism products.

"The government alone is not in a position to achieve economic development by transforming the agricultural sector and expanding industrial businesses to increase production and create jobs, promote exports and replace imports, make the economy self-sufficient and eliminate absolute poverty. This is only possible if the government partners with the private sector," said the President.

He said that the development and prosperity of Gandaki province would be possible only if the construction of Kaligandaki Corridor and Mid-Hill Highway was completed and Pokhara Airport and Korala Pass were made fully operational.

Speaking on the occasion, Chandra Prasad Dhakal, President of the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry, requested the complete and speedy operation of the development and tourism infrastructure of Gandaki province. Since Gandaki Province is physically connected to two big neighbours, India and China, and has many unique tourist areas like Pokhara, Manang, Mustang, Kaligandaki and Himalayas to Dhorpatan in Baglung, more efforts should be made to benefit from this, he suggested.

"India and China have a population of over 3 billion. Having a big tourism market nearby is a big opportunity. Therefore, the provincial government should pay attention to the fact that the construction of tourism infrastructure in this area can attract more tourists by air and land," said Dhakal.



PHOTO: RSS

A view of Ne-Pemasal, the base camp of Jugal mountain range of Sindhupalchowk district.

Health sector makes notable improvements

BY PALLAV BHUSAL
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

The government led by Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' is making notable improvements in major health sector indicators.

The Health Ministry has demonstrated its primary commitment to strengthening healthcare services at both local and national levels. The ministry has passed dozens of pending strategic medical action plans including on sexual violence and mental health and financial strategies.

According to Dr. Prakash Budathoki, spokesperson for the Ministry of Health and Population, it has asked health workers to return to their designated workplace. "Health Minister Mohan Bahadur Basnet has said that many health workers were taking deputation (kaaj) and are not working at their work location, mainly in rural areas. We have recognised nearly 800 health workers working outside their designated location and asked them to return for service," added Budathoki.

Similarly, Budathoki informed that the government has sent around 500 health workers who studied under government scholarships to rural areas for services.

"Another major development the government has ushered is the introduction of telemedicine services. Under this service, senior doctors residing in the urban areas can consult with doctors and patients in the rural areas through internet and telephone services," he said.

Use of this advance technology will help in the O.P.D. registration system and an electronic healthcare record, improving overall service for the patients, he added.

> The ministry has passed dozens of pending strategic medical action plans including on sexual violence and mental health and financial strategies.

One Year of Government

The World Health Organisation has recently presented a report saying that Nepal needs nearly 92,100 healthcare workers for the smooth operation of the health sector across the country.

"Currently, we have around 30,000 manpower delivering services in the health sector. This year the ministry has asked the local, provincial and central government to work together and come up with the required number of manpower to hire medical workers," said Budathoki.

The government plans to add another 30,000 health workers to boost health services across the country.

"The health ministry is working with the Education Ministry and Nepal Medical Education Commission to amend the medical education act to give opportunities to young people who desire to study medical subjects within the country," added Budathoki.

The government has provided free medical services to economically disadvantaged citizens and elderly people.

"There are around 3,000 beds across the country providing free services to financially disadvantaged groups and elderly people. We have also asked private hospitals to allocate 10 per cent beds for economically disadvantaged citizens," informed Budathoki.

The government has also constituted a committee to effectively implement insurance packages for health services.

Budathoki informed that the government has decided to start joint payment system which includes paying a 10 per cent service fee for expensive services and medicines. "We have started this policy so as to discourage the tendency of only taking advantage of the insurance system. This will help identify real economically disadvantaged citizens and these groups of people will not have to pay the 10 per cent fees to avail of medical services," he said.

All levels of government have come together to plan a fee structure in the health sector to ease and reduce the cost of medical treatment of Nepali citizens.

Likewise, the government has already completed the construction of 26 basic hospitals as a part of building hospitals at all local levels.

"The government has already allocated budget and plans to complete the construction of 100 basic hospitals this year. But, the local levels are providing health services by leasing buildings and operating hospitals," said Budathoki.

With the establishment of federalism, the government has made many improvements and fulfilled commitments in the health sector. With a rising population and lack of adequate manpower the government is continuously working to provide health services across the country by recognising problems and solving them quickly.

PM's address follow-up

Melamchi project working to supply water at earliest

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has assured that the government will bring the water of the Melamchi Water Supply Project (MWSP) to Kathmandu within next 28 days.

In his televised address to the nation on Tuesday, PM Prachanda stated, "I am working with a comprehensive plan to supply 170 million liters of water daily to the Kathmandu Valley within next 28 days."

Expressing empathy for the unfulfilled dream of the Kathmandu Valley residents to access water from the Project, he reassured that the narrative suggesting that the Melamchi Water Supply Project's water would not be supplied to Kathmandu would be proven wrong. He said that discussions on the second phase of the Melamchi Project were in progress, and a high priority would be given to the structural reform of the agencies related to water supply.

The work is progressing according to the PM's address, said Padam Kunwar, Senior Divisional Engineer at Melamchi Water Supply Board. "We are currently at Ambathan, extracting water from a small tunnel to assess its condition," he said. The tunnel was filled with water during the rainy season. Ambathan's tunnel is one of the tunnels connecting to the main tunnel at the Melamchi headworks.

"There are three gates, and there is no issue with Gate No. 1. We are currently addressing the issues with Gate No. 2, and work on Gate No. 9 within the headworks will commence on Friday," Kunwar explained.

Currently, six excavators, 10 tippers, eight to 10 engineers, and 10 labourers are mobilized in the field. When the work on Gate No. 9 begins, additional human resources and equipment will be deployed, Kunwar informed.

The work is going on under the specified insurance coverage and is expected to be completed ahead of the scheduled time frame, he mentioned.

Earlier, on December 19, the Ministry of Water Supply and the contracted company Sino Hydro signed a memorandum of understanding to facilitate the supply of Melamchi water to the Valley within next 28 days.

The meeting, chaired by Secretary at the Ministry Suresh Acharya, resolved to ensure the supply of Melamchi water to every household in Kathmandu within the specified timeframe, provided there was no emergency. The agreement was also made to mobilise resources immediately for the construction and clearance work.

The water will be processed by Kathmandu Upatyaka Khanepani Limited (KUKL) at Sundarijal Water Treatment Plant and redistributed to households in the Kathmandu Valley.

The Melamchi water supply was halted due to monsoon rains from June 23, 2023.

Coalition govt will last five years: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 27



Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the government of the present coalition parties will last for five years.

Speaking at a public interaction programme organised in Barpak Sulikot Rural Municipality-8, Gorkha, on Wednesday, Prime Minister Prachanda said that the government had made some records in its first year in office and said that many more good things would be done in the next four years.

He said, "In the past year, the government addressed the issues of citizenship and usury, made strides in social security and development, and led mountain countries to demand climate justice. If this much work can be done in one year, we can rest assured that much more will be done in the next four years."

Despite the government's many achievements, the Prime Minister said that anti-change and anti-republic forces would never acknowledge them. So, he requested the people and pro-transformation entities to promote the good that has been done.

"We have ensured proportional representation for all, including women and Dalits, and have taken Singha Durbar to the villages. We have to speak in favour of the positive changes that have occurred.

Conspirators are inaccurately trying to show the country as immersed in darkness, he said, stressing that the

» SEE PAGE 6

PAC asks to stop purchase of telecom monitoring system

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

The Public Accounts Committee (PAC) under the House of Representatives has directed the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology (MoCIT) and Nepal Telecommunication Authority (NTA) to stop purchasing of the Telecommunication Traffic Monitoring and Fraud Control System (TERAMOCS) and its establishment.

A meeting of the PAC chaired by Rishikesh Pokharel held on Wednesday directed the anti-graft body, Commission for Investigation of Abuse of Authority (CIAA), to study and begin the legal process of the procurement process adopted in TERAMOCS.

The Committee has also instructed the CIAA to update on the progress report of the study of the technology's procurement process in every 30 days to the Committee.

The direction of the Committee came after holding a meeting with the officials of the NTA, Nepal Telecom and other officials on Wednesday at Singha Durbar.

The Committee has raised 15 questions in regard to the need for the purchase of the technology and has also instructed to decide on purchasing and its implementation in 'as it is' condition.

In addition, the Committee has been instructed to conduct a thorough analysis of the work done so far in purchasing the system.

Chairman Rishikesh Pokharel said that the Authority has been instructed to submit the progress report every 30 days and if it is found that the authority has misused authority in its purchase, directed to begin the legal charge process according to the law.

The members of the PAC have raised questions regarding its tender process. It has been said that the expert of JAS Group's Sainath Naidu has been given the responsibility to prepare the draft of the tender process, and later, JAS Group's Naidu presented himself as representative of SJA Holding of Switzerland to get the tender in their favour. "It seems that the tender has been accepted despite a conflict of interest," according to the direction of the PAC.

The PAC has also claimed that

» SEE PAGE 6

Selfiekali crowned most beautiful elephant

BY BASANTA PARAJULI
Sauraha, Dec. 27

Selfiekali won this year's Elephant Beauty Contest, a unique and rare beauty pageant for elephants, held in Sauraha, Chitwan, on Wednesday.

On the second day of the Elephant Festival, Selfiekali, adorned in vibrant colours, paraded down a ramp and demonstrated various moves.

Dr. Bijay Shrestha, the judge for the contest and a veterinarian at Chitwan National Park, said, "Identifying the beauty of an elephant is a challenging task. However, based on the criteria set by the judges, Selfiekali was crowned with the title this year."

He said that the primary goals of the competitions were to enhance the bond between elephants and humans and to attract tourists.

Selfiekali, a 17-year-old, won the title and a cash prize of Rs. 15,000 by surpassing seven other contestants.

Similarly, an 11-year-old Rimjhimkali of Chitwan National Park became the 1st runner-up while Sambridikali of Ram Prasad Rijal became the 2nd runner-up. They won cash prizes of Rs. 10,000 and Rs. 5,000 respectively.



PHOTO: BASANTA PRAJULI/TRN

Selfiekali and other elephants participating in this year's Elephant Beauty Contest, a unique and rare beauty pageant for elephants, held in Sauraha, Chitwan, on Wednesday.

Other participants included Laxmikali owned by Haribhakta Ghimire, Bijulikali owned by Shanker Saiju, Dipak Bhattarai's Ranimayakali and Ram Kumar Chaudhary's Champakali.

Kishor Kumar, mahout of Selfiekali, said that she was the best in terms of discipline and behaviour. He said, "She was easy to tame due to her prompt response to human commands."

The competition was held among female elephants. The elephants were judged on cleanliness, nail trimming, absence of injuries and overall health.

> The competition was held among female elephants. The elephants were judged on cleanliness, nail trimming, absence of injuries and overall health.

The mahouts had painted their elephants with vibrant colours and designs enhancing their natural beauty and turning them into a living canvas. They also cleaned elephants and painted their nails in different colours.

Gunaraj Thapaliya, general secretary of the Regional Hotel Association in Sauraha, expressed his belief that the Elephant Beauty Contest had contributed to tourism promotion.

Sauraha, a tourist town, has been organising the Elephant Beauty Contest including the Elephant Festival.

Thapaliya said, "Such events deliver a message that elephants could be used in various ways for tourism promotion, not just for jungle safaris."

Earlier, a 32-year-old Champakali had won the title in a competition held on January 2, 2019 and Pujakali won in a contest on December 29, 2017.

8th Real Estate Expo kicks off



PHOTO: TRN

Nepal Land and Housing Developers Association entrepreneurs holding discussion at the 8th Real Estate Expo at the Bhrikutimandap Exhibition Centre in Kathmandu, Wednesday.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

Nepal Land and Housing Developers Association (NLHDA) is organising the 8th Real Estate Expo from Wednesday at the Bhrikutimandap Exhibition Centre in Kathmandu.

The expo will run till December 31.

It is expected that the fair will contribute to the development and expansion of this business by providing proper information about the current situation of the real estate business and its problems and solutions to future opportunities, the NLHDA said at a press conference held in the Capital on Wednesday.

"The expo will bring together businesses and consumers who are contributing significantly to scientific, orderly and safe land development and urbanisation," said the organiser, "We are confident that the businesses will bring their latest products to the consumers and the consumers will be able to get information about the reality and real situation of Nepali real estate business."

Local and foreign exhibitors will showcase their services and products at the Expo. Earthquake-resistant houses and apartments, land planning and development, manufacturers and sellers of construction materials, engineering and architecture consultants, as well as banks and insurance companies, will participate in the fair.

Likewise, business-like electrical goods, furniture, pipes, sanitary wire fitting, paints, vehicles, decorative goods and insurance, banking and architecture will display their products and also provide related consultancy services. In addition, if the interested participants want to launch their products and services during the fair period, that will also be arranged, said Bidur Dhamala, President of the NLHDA and Coordinator of the Expo Organising Committee.

According to him, stakeholders and spectators involved in the purchase and sale of houses and apartments developed in a planned manner will be able to get detailed information about the facility, price and other aspects.

"We believe that this fair will become a common platform for businesses, investors, consumers, construction material sellers and service providers involved in housing and apartment projects. We expect that at least 65,000 visitors will visit the fair which will feature more than 60 stalls," said Dhamala.

China sanctions a US research firm

AP
Beijing, Dec. 27

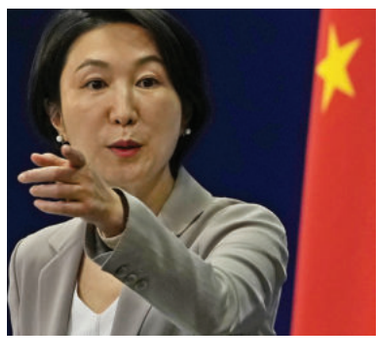
China says it is banning a United States research company and two analysts who have reported extensively on claims of human rights abuses committed against Uyghurs and other Muslim minority groups native to the country's far northwestern region of Xinjiang.

Foreign Ministry spokesperson Mao Ning was quoted as announcing late Tuesday night that Los Angeles-based research and data analytics firm Kharon, its director of investigations, Edmund Xu, and Nicole Morgret, a human rights analyst affiliated with the Center for Advanced Defense Studies, would be barred from traveling to China. Also, any assets or property they have in China will be frozen and organizations and individuals in China are prohibited from making transactions or otherwise cooperating with them.

In a statement on the Ministry of Foreign Affairs website, Mao said the sanctions against the company, Xu and Morgret were retaliation for a yearly U.S. government report on human rights in Xinjiang. Uyghurs and other natives of the region share religious, linguistic and cultural links with the scattered peoples of Central Asia and have long resented the Chinese Communist Party's heavy-handed control and attempts to assimilate them with the majority Han ethnic group.

In a paper published in June 2022, Morgret wrote, "The Chinese government is undertaking a concerted drive to industrialize the Xinjiang Uyghur Autonomous Region (XUAR), which has led an increasing number of corporations to establish manufacturing operations there. This centrally-controlled industrial policy is a key tool in the government's efforts to forcibly assimilate Uyghurs and other Turkic peoples through the institution of a coerced labour regime."

Such reports draw from a wide range of sources, including independent media, non-governmental organizations and groups that may receive commercial and governmental grants or other outside funding.



FILE PHOTO: AP

Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Mao Ning gestures during a press conference at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs in Beijing, on July 26, 2023.

Elderly man weaving, carrying and selling baskets at 64

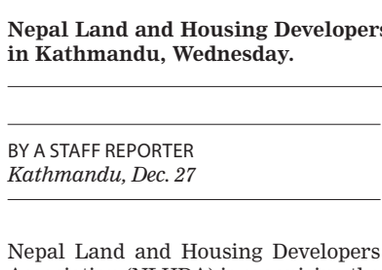


PHOTO: RAJAN RAWAT/TRN

Jaisingh Tamta of Kharpunath Rural Municipality-5, Humla.

BY RAJAN RAWAT
Humla, Dec. 27

A 64-year-old man here has been found maintaining his livelihood by selling bamboo-made baskets for 42 years.

Jaisingh Tamta of Kharpunath Rural Municipality-5 has spent most of his time weaving bamboo baskets and selling them in the local markets and neighbouring villages.

Tamta said that he has been engaging in making bamboo baskets for the last 42 years. He sells the baskets by visiting the villages and marketplaces carrying them on his back.

He further said that his daily routine was to weave bamboo baskets and visit villages carrying them to sell.

His spouse supports collecting the Himalayan bamboo (Nigalo). He also goes to the forest to collect it. He weaves the bamboo baskets throughout the year and takes them to the villages and markets whenever he wants to sell them.

He said that he has been weaving bamboo baskets with his hand. He weaves a basket on a long day and when the days are shorter, he takes two days to complete a basket.

Bamboo baskets are being sold in different villages of Simkot and Kharpunath Rural Municipalities. He has been selling a big basket at Rs. 1,200 and a small one (Daalo) at Rs. 800.

He has been selling 200 bamboo baskets and 150 Daalos a year. Even at the age of 64 years, he has been supporting his family by making a good income.

He has been weaving and selling bamboo baskets since he was 22 years old. He has demanded modern skills and techniques to make bamboo baskets but so far he has not received such facilities from any authority.

Farmers in Taplejung become happy after kiwi fruit gets good market

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Taplejung, Dec. 27

Export of the kiwi fruit produced in Taplejung has elated the local farmers.

Earlier, farmers had been suffering from a lack of market but recently kiwis of Taplejune are being supplied to Jhapa, Kathmandu and other places outside the district.

According to Sagar Ijam Limbu, a resident of Pathibhara Yangwarak Rural Municipality-3, Tiringe, the kiwi fruit produced here this year has been supplied to the markets in Damak and Kathmandu. Limbu informed that more than 15 quintals kiwi produced in Tiringe is sent outside the district. According to him, about 25 quintals of kiwi were supplied outside the district last year.

Limbu said that as hail caused damage to the fruit this year, kiwi production has been affected and there is no shortage of market for the produce.

According to him, the buyers have purchased kiwi fruit at a price of up to Rs. 100 per kilo. Local farmers have also said that they have not been able to supply kiwi according to the demand of the buyers. According to them, 500,000 to 700,000 kgs of kiwi would have been produced during the rainy season this year if the hail had not damaged the crop.

Tiringe village is considered a pocket area for kiwi production therefore the local body has announced it so. It is said that after the announcement of the pocket area for kiwi cultivation, the rural municipality is also giving subsidies to the farmers involved in the production of the fruit.

Limbu also informed that five different private agricultural firms of kiwi cultivation are being operated with the help of the provincial government through Agricultural Knowledge Centre Taplejung.

According to him, the state government through Agricultural Knowledge Centre gave a subsidy of Rs. 500,000 to each agricultural firm. Likewise, local farmers said that the rural municipality has been providing continuous subsidy support for kiwi cultivation management and plant production and purchase.

Farmers have been cultivating kiwi in most of the areas of the district including Tiringe. In the beginning, there was no market for kiwi, and the farmers involved in farming were desperate. Rajkumar Gurung, a resident of Phungling Municipality-7, said that kiwis are being sold well in the local market and are being regularly sent outside the district.

According to him, the fruit is sold from Rs. 100 to Rs. 200 per kilogram according to the size and quality. He also informed that the demand from traders outside the district is increasing as the kiwi produced here is 'tasty'.

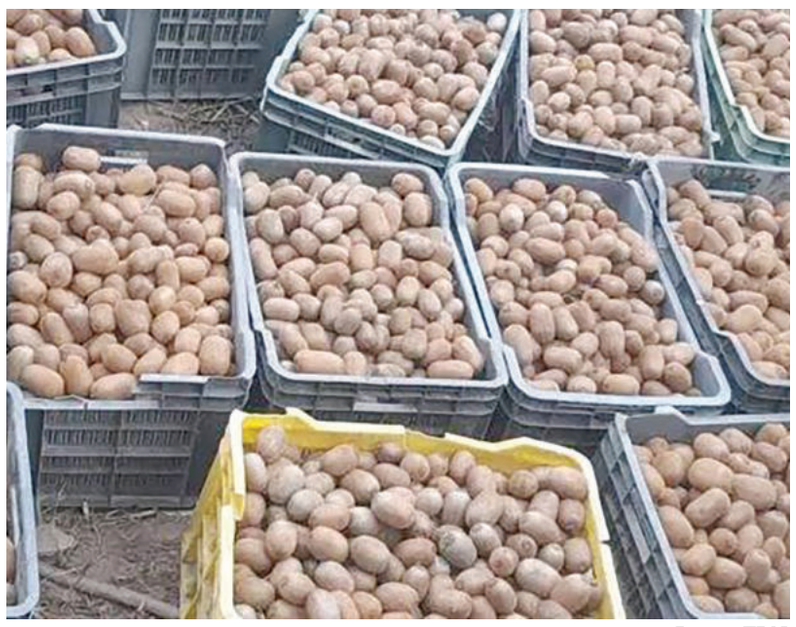


PHOTO: TRN

Kiwi produced at Pathibhara Yangwarak Rural Municipality-3, Tiring has accurate size to sell in the market.

TEPCO'S OPERATIONAL BAN IS LIFTED

AP
Tokyo, Dec. 27

Japanese nuclear safety regulators lifted an operational ban Wednesday imposed on a nuclear plant owned by Tokyo Electric Power Company Holdings, the operator behind the Fukushima plant that ended in disaster, allowing the company to resume preparations for restarting the Kashiwazaki-Kariwa plant after more than 10 years.

At its weekly meeting, the Nuclear Regulation Authority formally lifted the more than two-year ban imposed on the TEPCO's Kashiwazaki-Kariwa plant over its lax safety measures at the site, saying a series of inspections and meetings with company officials has shown sufficient improvement. The decision removes an order that prohibited TEPCO from transporting new fuel into the plant or placing it into reactors, a necessary step for restarting Kashiwazaki-Kariwa's reactors.

The plant on Japan's northern coast of Niigata is TEPCO's only workable nuclear power plant since the March 2011 earthquake and tsunami destroyed its Fukushima Daiichi plant and caused Fukushima Daini plant to cease operations.

For the company now burdened with the growing cost of decommissioning the Fukushima Daiichi plant and compensating disaster-hit residents, restarting the Kashiwazaki-Kariwa reactors soon is key to stabilizing its business.

TEPCO President Tomoaki Kobayakawa told reporters Wednesday that it was too early to comment on the prospect for the restart. He said the company will provide its safety and security measures to gain understanding from the local residents, who must approve a restart.

The NRA slapped an unprecedented ban on the operator in April 2021 after revelations of a series of sloppy anti-terrorism measures at TEPCO's Kashiwazaki-Kariwa plant, the world's largest nuclear power complex housing seven reactors.

The Kashiwazaki-Kariwa plant was partially damaged in a 2007 earthquake, causing safety concerns and distrust among local municipalities.

GOVERNMENT OF NEPAL (GoN)
MASTER GENERAL OF ORDNANCE (PROVISION)
NEPALI ARMY HEADQUARTERS, BHADRAKALI, KATHMANDU, NEPAL

Invitation e-Bids for Observations & Identification Equipment

First Date of Publication: 28 December, 2023

1. The Master General of Ordnance (MGO) (Provision), Nepali Army Headquarters invites electronic bids from eligible bidders for the procurement of the following items required for the Nepali Army under International Competitive Bidding (ICB) procedures specified in Public Procurement Act and Regulations:

S.No.	Contract Identification No:	Description of Item	Quantity	Price of Bid Document NRs	Bid Bond Amount NRs	Bid Validity	Pre-bid Meeting	Last date of Bid submission	Bid Opening
1.	MGO/Observations & Identification Equipment/080/81/25 (DPO)	Binocular Handheld	232 set	5,000.00	16,30,000.00	90 Days	1100 hours NST of 12 January, 2024.	1200 Hours NST of 11 February, 2024.	1300 Hours NST of 11 February, 2024.
		LRF Tripod Mounted	43 set						
		LRF Handheld	97 set						
		Binocular Tripod Mounted	12 set						
		Compass	245 set						

2. Eligible Bidders may visit PPMO's e-GP system www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp or obtain further information and inspect the bidding documents at the Office of MGO (Provision), Nepali Army Headquarters, Bhadrakali, Kathmandu, Nepal (Tel. +977-1-5979124) during office hours. Bids must be accompanied by bid security, amounting to above mentioned **bid bond amount** (Equivalent amount in bid currency at selling exchange rate published by Nepal Rastra Bank on bid notice publication date).
3. Fee of bidding document must be deposited in Account Name Nepali Army Welfare Fund, Jangi Adda to Account No. 00101010264181 of Nepal Investment Bank Limited.

President prays at Kalika Bhagwati Temple



PHOTO: THAKUR PRASAD ACHARYA/TRN

President Ramchandra Paudel visits Kalika Bhagawati temple in Baglung on Wednesday.

BY THAKUR PRASAD ACHARYA
Baglung, Dec. 27

President Ramchandra Paudel has prayed at the famous Kalika Bhagwati Temple in Baglung. President Paudel, who came to Baglung on Wednesday morning to inaugurate the 7th Baglung Festival, reached the temple and worshipped the goddess.

After the worship, the temple's management committee honoured the President with a certificate. The committee's chairman Kumar Khadka also gifted him a wooden model of the Kalika Bhagwati Temple.

Khadka expressed gratitude for the President's visit and said that it would help bring tourists.

The same day, President Paudel also visited the Shaligram Museum at Kundele.

SENIOR CITIZENS ARE LIKE A LIVING SCHOOL: FORMER PRESIDENT BHANDARI

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

Former President Bidya Devi Bhandari has described the senior citizens who are filled with knowledge, skill and experience obtained through lifelong struggle and suffering as the living school. The former Head of the State stated this in a message of best wishes she gave today on the occasion of the National Senior Citizen Day, 2080.

She viewed that the new generation can learn lessons useful in life from the intrinsic knowledge, skills and experiences the senior citizen retain, which can be utilised for the development and progress of the nation.

Stating that an unprecedented change is witnessed in our family structure also due to the changes that have come in the living condition and style and migration, among others since the last few decades, the former President said that instead of living in a large extended family, the trend of living in a small single family is increasing these days.

"It is experienced that the environment for the senior citizens to enjoy life economically, socially and mentally has been declining in such context. Collective initiatives of the family, society and the state are required for making the life easier, secure and ensuring a dignified life for the senior citizens who have reached towards the later phase of life while saving our family system, norms and values, culture and civilization based on oriental culture."

Education bill in parliament; timely access to textbooks ensured

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

The government has included registration of the bill related to school education in the parliament and easy availability of textbooks as its achievements in the education sector in a year.

After the enforcement of the Nepal Constitution with a new federal republic in the country, the bill related to school education has been taken among the essentials for fulfilling fundamental rights and administrative restructuring in every sector.

The stakeholders comprising education sector advocates and province and local governments had been demanding enactment of the Federal Education Act at the earliest.

Due to the delay in introducing the Act, there has been persisting confusion in the scope of work and responsibilities among the three tiers of the government.

Various debates have been made regarding the federal education bill after its registration o in the parliament.

The incumbent government has put the education bill on priority since most of the parties in last year's election had emphatically included this agenda in their manifestoes.

In his address to the nation on the occasion of a year completion of the government on Tuesday, Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' reiterated his emphasis on endorsing the school bill after adequate discussion in the parliament.

The stakeholders comprising education sector advocates and province and local governments had been demanding enactment of the Federal Education Act at the earliest.

The bill was registered at the House of Representatives (HoR) on September 13 this year.

The HOR Education, Health and Information Technology Committee commenced deliberations on 1,758 amendment proposals on the bill since December 24.

Likewise, in the period, the government has freely distributed textbooks to around 5.2 million students of public schools from grade 1 to 12 before the start of the educational year.

It has averted the unavailability of paper, delay in the revision of the curriculum and deficit recurrent budget in Janak Education Material Center.

Nepal to present ritual Bhar during Ram Temple inauguration

BY LAXMI CHAUDHARY
Janakpurdham, Dec. 27



PHOTO: LAXMI CHAUDHARY/TRN

For the first time since the Treta Yuga, Nepal is going to send a Bhar (food and non-food items gifted to married daughters and their in-laws) to India on behalf of her daughter Sita. A team of 251 people, led by Ram Roshan Das, successor to the Mahanth (head priest) of the Janaki Temple, will be travelling from Nepal's Janakpurdham to India's Ayodhya with the Bhar next month on the latter's invitation. They shall be going to Ayodhya, India, to attend the inauguration of the newly built Ram Temple there on January 22, 2024.

In Mithila, it is customary for a family to send jewellery, clothes and food to their married daughter, her husband and her husband's family when she and her in-laws move into a new house. In line with this tradition, Janakpurdham's Janaki Temple will be sending the Bhar to Sita and her husband Ram, informed Das. He also appealed to the residents of Janakpur to help arrange things like fruits to gift to India.

The Nepali team is scheduled to leave for Ayodhya on January 4. So, he urged everyone to send their items by January 3. He also requested people to put the items in a bamboo basket and write their names on the outside. If everything goes as planned, the team will reach Ayodhya on January 5 and will hand over the Bhar to the Ram Temple Trust a day later at 9 in the morning.

A team from Nepal, led by Janaki Temple's Mahanth Ram Tapeshwor Das, had gone to Ayodhya in 2020 too to participate in the Ram Temple's ground-breaking ceremony. At the time, they had taken soil from Janakpur and five silver bricks.

Mahanth not participating

Janaki Temple's Mahanth Ram Tapeshwor Das, however, has said that he will not be part of the Bhar -gifting group. "I will take as much as I can but I am not part of the Bhar team," he said, clarifying that his decision was based on Janakpur's apparent lack of coordination with Ayodhya. "In our last trip, the people of Ayodhya welcomed us with open arms. But, at the [Ram Temple] site itself, security was so tight that not even a bird could fly in without the [Ram Temple] Trust's permission."

"So, it might not be appropriate for us to send a grand Bhar from here without first consulting with the Indian side. I would urge everyone involved to first understand the ground situation there," he explained his stance.

But, successor Ram Roshan Das maintained that it was a matter of pride for everyone in Janakpurdham to be representing Lord Ram's in-laws and presenting him with the special Bhar during the inauguration of his temple. "This is not merely a ceremony for the Janaki Temple. This is an occasion for the entire Mithilanchal," he said.

Speaking at a press conference organised at the Janaki Temple on Tuesday, he informed that the entire function was being coordinated by the Vishva Hindu Parishad (VHP) so there was no need to worry. VHP officials as well as representatives from the Janakpurdham Sub-Metropolitan City were also present at the conference. Meanwhile, Janakpurdham's Mayor Manoj Kumar Sah said that the Nepali team had been given half an hour to present the Bhar and that Ayodhya was eager to welcome Lord Ram's in-laws. He also asked all to refrain from bringing the holy Janaki Temple into controversy.

KMC to install lifts at overhead bridge in Baneshwor

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

The Kathmandu Metropolitan City (KMC) has planned to install lifts at an overhead bridge in Baneshwor for convenience of senior citizens. According to Metropolis traffic advisor Jagatman Shrestha, they plan to fix a lift each at both sides of the bridge. Though the facility is primarily targeted at senior citizens, people who need it can use it.

It will be beneficial for physically incapacitated, people with disabilities and children. Eight people can use a lift at once.

The local government allocated Rs 50 million to implement the project in the current fiscal year. As Shrestha said, a bidding process has neared the final phase and it will be materialized in a week. Some volunteers will be mobilised to supervise the elevators.

The local government is also focused on improving conditions of roadways within its jurisdictions and allocated Rs 440 million for the plan in the current fiscal year.

SSB obstructs temporary bridge construction

BY LAXMI CHAUDHARY
Janakpurdham, Dec. 27



PHOTO: LAXMI CHAUDHARY /TRN

Jamuni River's bridge construction area left ignorantly as seen in the picture after the obstruction.

Naresh Prasad Yadav, chairman of Ward No 2 of Mukhiyapatti Musaharniya Rural Municipality along the Nepal-India border in Dhanusha district, has complained that he has been unable to build a temporary bridge over the Jamuni River because of the trouble created by the Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB) of India.

Yadav said that when the river changed its course, the arable land of many farmers in the ward reached across the Jamuni River near the Nepal-India border. Although the two sides officially agreed to allow the Nepali farmers to cultivate there, in the absence of a bridge to cross the river, farmers have been forced to leave their fields barren.

Similarly, Rajkumari Yadav of the same village said that the people travelling during the rainy season have to face difficulties because of lack of physical structures like bridges.

She said, "My mother's place is in Jayanagar, India. Members of my husband's family and my maternal family frequently visit both India and Nepal, however, due to the lack of a bridge for smooth movement at the border, they have to face difficulties," she said. The people of the village were happy when they heard that a bridge was going to be built in the border area, but when SSB of India did not allow the construction of the bridge, the work had been lying idle for years.

"Temporary crossings made using the Hume pipes could be used only for a certain time. Therefore, the citizens of both countries are facing difficulty in commuting," ward chair Yadav said. He said that most of the rivers could be easily crossed during the dry season, but during the rainy season, it was difficult to cross them.

Rajkumari also questioned what kind of relationship the two neighbouring countries have been enjoying. "I have been a witness to this situation for 34 years, the condition of the border area is the same as it was 34 years ago when I came here as a bride. The only difference is that the river has changed its course," she said.

Avinash Chaudhary, a local of Jatahi in Dhanusha Nagarine Municipality, said that the rules should be equal for the citizens of both countries. However, the SSB personnel easily enter Nepal without seeking permission at any time and go back to India across the border. "Leaders of Nepal hesitate to raise the border issue, this is why the bridge of Jatahi border point has not been built," he said.

Even though when the representatives of the Nepali people are trying to build a new structure next to the old bridge, SSB has not allowed them to build it, he added. According to Rajiv Jha, Chairman of Nepal-India Open Border Dialogue Group, the people of the border area have to suffer when the open border between Nepal and India has not been managed in such a way that could help make the relationship between the two countries more harmonious.

His organisation has also been reporting time and again about excesses on the Nepal-India border. Chairman Jha said that according to the 1950 Friendship Treaty between Nepal and India, the citizens of the two countries should be treated equally. Citizens of both countries should be able to move from one country to another with respect. However, citizens of Nepal here are treated disrespectfully, Jha said.

The Border Dialogue Group has repeatedly raised its voice on such issues, demanding that the governments of both countries should be serious about ending the abusive behaviours at the border area. Devi Sahai Meena, Consul General of the Consulate General of the Government of India in Birgunj, said that it was not appropriate to give any response on the phone about the issue relating to the border area.

Nepal Electricity Authority
Distribution and Consumer Services Directorate
Durbar Marga, Kathmandu, Nepal

Notification of Intent to Award the Contract

(Date of Publication : 28 December 2023)

Pursuant to Clause 43 of Instructions to Bidders of bidding document, the concerned bidders are notified that the Nepal Electricity Authority intends to award the contract to the lowest evaluated substantially responsive bidder as mentioned below:

S. N.	IFB No. and Title	Lowest Evaluated Substantially Responsive Bidder	Amount
1	ICB/DCSD-079/80-27: Supply and Delivery of HT Metering Unit dated 08 August 2023	Shenzhen Chuangyin Co. Ltd., China	USD 971,200.00 (Excluding Custom and VAT)

Notice for Intent to award the contract

(Date of Publication : 28 December, 2023)

Pursuant to sub clause 27.2 and 27.3 of Public Procurement Act 2063, this is to notify all concerned bidders that it is our intention to award the contract to the following bidder for the Tender Notice No. KSCL/U/ICB-156/080/081 for Supply and Delivery of 30,000±2% MT of Urea as per the Invitation for Bids published on 29 October, 2023 in 'The Rising Nepal' & www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp as it is found substantially responsive and lowest evaluated bidder.

Tender Notice No.	Name of the successful bidder	Bidder rate in USD	Total Amount
KSCL/U/ICB-156/080/081	M/S SUN International FZE., Dubai, UAE	CIP Birgunj - CIP Biratnagar - CIP Bhairahawa- } 449.15	USD 1,34,74,500.00

KRISHI SAMAGRI COMPANY LTD.
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E-mail: aicl.nepal@gmail.com

Nepal Airlines Corporation
Human Resources Department

Request for Application from Pilots for DHC-6 (Twin-otter) Fleet on contract basis

(1st date of publication : 2080/09/12 (28 December, 2023)

Nepal Airlines Corporation is seeking applications from qualified and eligible Nepali Citizen **Pilots for positions within the DHC-6 (Twin-otter) Fleet** on a contractual basis. Interested individuals are invited to submit their applications along with a comprehensive CV and relevant eligibility documents, within 15 days from the initial publication date of this notice. Please address your submissions to the following:

Human Resources Department
Nepal Airlines Corporation
New Road Kathmandu Nepal
Email: vacancy2019.nac@gmail.com / hrplanning@nac.com.np
Phone: 977-01-5718557 (Ext. 2168, 2319)

For details of qualification and fleet specific requirements, please visit official website (www.nepalairlines.com.np) of Nepal Airlines Corporation.

Human Resources Department

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

Learning how to be still, to really be still and let life happen - that stillness becomes radiance.
- Morgan Freeman

EDITORIAL

Pledge For Better Results

The coalition government, led by Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda, has completed one year in office on Wednesday (Dec 11). In the initial days when the government came into existence amidst chaotic political environment, the PM faced challenges in choosing the right allies. However, the confusion was gradually over and the PM succeeded in mustering the support of the political parties, enabling him to command more than majority in the federal parliament. Then, the government picked up the momentum, with a series of measures to attain good governance, economic recovery, and effective service delivery. Its anti-corruption crusade drew praise from the public and the COVID-hit economy was brought back on track through stimulus and flexible monetary policy. The government's climate diplomacy put spotlight on the precious Himalayas that are melting fast due to rising global warming. Significant gain was made in the hydropower development.

On Tuesday when the Prime Minister addressed the nation on the occasion, he did not mince his words. He said that the government did not fail but the outcomes fell short of his expectations. The PM did not only mention the progress made in the last one year but also rolled out his schemes for coming year. Formed following the second general elections under the new constitution, the people have pinned high hopes on the current dispensation obliged to resolve burning issues related to basic service delivery, development, employment and implementation of federalism, among others. Unsatisfied with the current style of working, the PM has vowed to change operational approach of the government in order to have better results. For this, he is set to overhaul the Prime Minister's Office this week to give a message of change. PM Prachanda has announced that the 2080s would be the decade of rapid development.

Positive indicators have been witnessed in the economic sector. For instance, the consumer price has gone down by 2.7 per cent. The government is now focusing on lowering the inflation that has caused economic hardships to the people. It is going to effectively implement the Health Insurance Act to integrate all free programmes, excluding the fundamental ones, into a unified health insurance framework. Some high profile political leaders and senior government officials are now behind bars for their involvement in various corruption cases and forgeries. This shows that the government is determined to check corruption and end impunity. The PM said that the government would appoint the top officials in the universities based on meritocracy and end the practice of political appointment that has been blamed for the erosion of quality of education and prestige of the country's oldest university – Tribhuvan University.

This year, a total of 776.61 kilometres of roads have been blacktopped and 587.5 kilometres graveled. Likewise, 181.29 km of new track has been opened and an additional 162,000 safe houses have been constructed and provided to the beneficiaries. Altogether four border entry points between Nepal and China have been opened. The PM is working with a compact plan of 28 days to bring water from Melamchi to the residents of Kathmandu. The minimum wage of workers has been increased to Rs. 17,350 and more than 950,000 people who have gone for foreign employment or are self-employed abroad have been included in the contribution-based social security scheme. The real farmers will get agricultural loans at subsidised rates. Around 400,000 tonnes of chemical fertilizer supply has been ensured on time. Balanced relationships have been maintained with India and China. The government is on track and expected to make bigger achievements next year.

Machine Intimacy

KYLE D. KILLIAN

Whether it's a care robot in a nursing home or hospital, or an AI "entity" to chat with, machine intimacy is attractive to many people, perhaps because it lessens their sense of vulnerability. But as MIT sociologist Sherry Terkel argues, "intimacy without vulnerability is not intimacy at all." She asks us to consider how a machine like ChatBot, without a life or a body, that's never been in love and does not face mortality, is going to provide human beings with caring and understanding. Can a machine empathise? Can it feel?

While the answers to these questions remain a resolute "no" at this point in time, that doesn't stop some people from imbuing and investing in machines, and the kind of pseudo-intimacy they offer, with human qualities and emotions. In the process of anthropomorphising AI, humans begin to see their interactions as constituting an intimate relationship when they aren't. The responses from AI stem from its programming and its ability to incorporate new data inputs from the human user (and a variety of other sources), but it does not reply as a living, sentient being capable of feeling.

What's really interesting about the phenomenon of machine intimacy is that AI can pass at least some elements of the Turing test not because it is "alive" or actually sentient, but humans' standards for what might constitute a "real relationship", or who or what can pass for a friend, lover or confidante, may not be particularly lofty or demanding. Why is this? From my reading of Terkle's research and my observations of friends and clients since COVID-19 hit the scene, many members of our species are perfectly willing to forgo interactions with other humans because of the risk of rejection, criticism, conflict, or disappointment.

In the real world, real people sometimes let us down, are not on the same page as us, or simply "don't feel the same way" about us as we feel about them. In addition, rejection sensitivity is a thing. A machine won't assault us, break up with us, or leave, and it can't really die, as long as its programming and data are backed up somewhere. It's not likely to be cruel or sadistic, unless you want it to be, and then it can learn how to do that with you. But is that sexy or "hot"? Does it involve disclosure or actual vulnerability? Is anything riding on that scenario?

AI is a different species, a machine with parts, trying to keep up with our inputs in real time, and no matter how much we project onto it the role of partner, confidante, or lover, it isn't one. To the extent that we permit ourselves the luxury of that illusion, we start becoming a little less adventuresome, a little less risk-taking, a little less human. In the second season of the TV series Fleabag, Kristin Scott Thomas' character has a far-ranging conversation with Phoebe Bridgers' protagonist.

One of the profound things she imparts is, "It's not really a party unless someone flirts with you." The major downside of getting older, she says, is that "People don't really flirt with you anymore, not really, not with danger... Do not take that for granted. There is nothing more exciting than a room full of people." Can we sustain the excitement, the energy, the potential captured in this quotation when AI relentlessly and seductively beckons from stage left, promising a form of connection that involves no risk, danger, or stakes? As Chaucer wrote, "Nothing ventured, nothing gained."

- Psychology Today

How To Assess Outcome Of COP28



Gernot Wagner

"#Actionism." That word greeted arriving passengers at Dubai International Airport, the port of entry for the vast majority of the 100,000 or so climate negotiators, activists, industry lobbyists, and others attending this year's United Nations Climate Change Conference and the events around it. It flickered from ads in the oddly underused metro connecting the airport directly to the official COP28 venue, and it was displayed on the occasional billboard along the two main "roads" spanning the length of the city, each with at least a dozen lanes. Apparently, the neologism is meant to convey not just action, but "vigorous action to bring about change."

This attempt to rebrand an everyday word encapsulates COP28, surely one of the most surreal climate summits to date. Between Dubai's ostentatious fossil-fueled wealth, misguided car-centric city planning, and the fact that COP28 itself was led by a fossil-fuel CEO, it has been much easier than in prior years to be cynical about the whole exercise. But cynicism will not help us address climate change, and while it was tough to spot amid all the greenwashing, there was some real progress on the ground. Two weeks before the conference, the United Arab Emirates opened the world's largest single-site solar plant, with two gigawatts of panels spanning 20 square kilometres and powering almost 200,000 energy-hogging UAE homes for $0.0132 per kilowatt-hour – one of the lowest prices for electricity anywhere delivered at this scale.

Energy efficiency

Nor is this the only development to applaud. The renewables lobby is celebrating a pledge, supported by 118 governments, to triple global renewable-energy capacity and double the annual rate of energy efficiency improvements by 2030. The nuclear industry also has reason to cheer, with 22 governments pledging to triple global nuclear-energy capacity by 2050. Both commitments are good news for the climate. The world needs both renewables and nuclear in order to cut fossil-fuel use quickly. Building low-carbon capacity fast is what matters, more so than whether the COP28 agreement includes the words "phase out," "phase down," or a sentence about "transitioning away from fossil fuels."1

Precisely because the world needs to cut fossil-fuel use altogether, it is more difficult to evaluate another pledge made this month to reduce methane (CH4). While carbon dioxide (CO2) is the biggest overall climate culprit, CH4 will be responsible for as much as 45 per cent of the planetary warming this decade – even though it doesn't remain in the atmosphere for nearly as long as CO2. So it was much more than just well-timed symbolism when the US Environmental Protection Agency announced on December 2, the first Saturday of COP28, that it had finalised a long-awaited rule to cut CH4 emissions from the oil and gas sector by around 80 per cent over 15 years.

That news came with a $1 billion commitment to help smaller countries address the same problem, leading several to join the Global Methane Pledge (launched at COP26 in Glasgow and strengthened at COP27 in Sharm El-Sheikh) to cut total CH4 emissions 30 per cent by 2030. And all this comes on the heels of an EU law that sets tight CH4 leakage standards. In classic EU regulatory fashion, that provision should reach well beyond European

> Precisely because the world needs to cut fossil-fuel use altogether, it is more difficult to evaluate another pledge made this month to reduce methane (CH4).

borders. December 2 also brought a major industry announcement. Around 50 of the world's largest oil and gas firms – including ExxonMobil, Shell, SaudiAramco, and ADNOC (the company led by Sultan al Jaber, the COP28 president) – pledged to all but eliminate their own CH4 emissions. That means addressing both venting and the routine flaring of CH4. Though the latter practice has been banned for two decades in the UAE, it remains a major contributor to the constant haze and air pollution engulfing Dubai. Here's hoping that "actionism" will finally turn this pledge into reality.

Climate campaigners are understandably questioning the industry's motives, and emphasising that such pledges could detract from the need to cut both CH4 and CO2 emissions from fossil-fuel use, not merely from its production. They can cite comments like one by Occidental Petroleum CEO Vicki Hollub, who told S&P Global's CERAWeek conference earlier this year that Occidental's purchase of direct-air-capture technology "gives our industry a license to continue to operate for the 60, 70, 80 years that I think it's going to be very much needed."

Narrow technical perspective

None of that diminishes the real, positive effects that would come from slashing CH4 emissions this decade (or from scaling up carbon-removal technologies, for that matter). But the question of how useful the COP process has been raises an even broader, almost philosophical one: How should we think about CO2, CH4, or any other emissions reductions that are ostensibly "costless" (or even profitable) from a narrow technical perspective, but that have yet to happen? After all, oil and gas companies here are committing to stop wasting gas, one of their two main products – and an increasingly important and lucrative one at that. Ideally, it would not take the performative circus of COP to achieve these kinds of agreements. Yet, as the CH4 pledge shows, apparently it does.

The problem is that coordinating pledges across industry players, civil society, and governments to measure, report, verify, and ultimately enforce action via a unified set of standards takes time and effort. It is for good reason that the acronym-laden COP process has turned "MRV" into a verb. The task now will be to MRV(E) – measure, report, verify, and enforce – the pledges on renewables, nuclear, and CH4 coming out of COP28, while also keeping the larger picture in mind. There are clear hurdles to overcome, even – or perhaps especially – with seemingly costless emissions reductions that industries themselves have an interest in adopting. The key task for international gatherings, as for low-carbon technologies themselves, is to focus on getting costs down, and fast. Judged by that benchmark, COP28 may yet prove to be at least as important a stepping stone in the global clean-energy race as any of the previous UN climate summits.

(Wagner is a climate economist at Columbia Business School.)
-Project Syndicate

Women In Hydropower Sector



Sanju Adhikari

Nepal is one of the richest countries in water resources where over 6,000 rivers and rivulets run across the country. Steep topography of the country offers high possibilities for hydropower generation. Out of the total feasible generation capacity of around 83,000 megawatts, around 42,000 megawatts has been considered economically feasible. Hydropower plays a predominant role in Nepal's electricity system as well as its economy. The Nepal Electricity Authority (NEA), a state-owned company, had sole authority for production, transmission and distribution of electricity in Nepal before 1912.

With the introduction of the Electricity Act 1992 and the Hydropower Policy 2001, hydropower licenses were distributed and power purchase agreement got signed with private hydropower investors. After the entry of the private sector, the power generation activities got a significant boost. As per the 2021 World Bank study, about 90 per cent of the country's population has access to electricity, a remarkable achievement. The electricity production has increased with every passing year, and now, it has started exporting energy to neighbouring India.

Women's participation

The total population of Nepal on Census Day (November 25, 2021) was 29,164,578. Of this, the males population was 14,253,551 (48.87 per cent) and that of females, 14,911,027 (51.13). The sex ratio was 95.59 males per 100 females. According to the detailed census report, the literacy rate of the population aged five years and above was 76.3 per cent, the male literacy rate was 83.6 per cent and female literacy 69.4 per cent. Women's involvement in economic opportunities are largely limited within domestic affairs and not accounted in Gross Domestic Product calculation of a nation. The active participation of women in project design and its development process has been a critical issue. Women's everyday life is associated with protection and use of natural resources.

Since the large population of men are in foreign employment opportunities, women are carrying responsibilities of home, elders, children and family occupation like farming, poultry etc. Women's participation and their engagement in hydropower project are critical components for its successful completion. Hydropower Environment Assessment Manual 2018 ensures to acquire the gender disintegration data during the Environment Impact Assessment (EIA). It focuses on including gender-related impacts such as employment, marginalisation, SES/SH, impact due to influx of migrant workers, crime, trafficking, and loss of livelihood opportunities. Environment Protection Act 2076 and its Regulation 2077 has provisioned for public hearing and notification in national newspaper in the process of impact assessment.

However, it is silent on inclusive participation and mandatory presence of women's participation in these consultations. In the case of the projects financed by international financing institutions (IFIs), due to their mandatory policy for inclusive consultation,

> During the hydropower infrastructure development, women can benefit from direct employment opportunities as well as by operating small business.

some developers are trying to get to the minimum figure required. In the case of the project promoted by private developers and NEA, the participation of women and vulnerable communities is significantly ignored.

Expansion of electricity supply will bring about considerable positive changes in the communities of both men and women. It can bring positive economic changes through better job opportunities, effective health services, and access to education. During the hydropower infrastructure development, women can benefit from direct employment opportunities as well as by operating small business. In post-construction phase, however, there are a lot of job opportunities, which can uplift status of women alongside their day-to-day life. However, women are deprived of opportunities during the time of power generation, transmission and distribution. The existing socio-cultural dynamics of the communities and power relations in households impede women's active participation in planning and development of power generation projects.

Barriers

Illiteracy is considered one of the major constraints that hinder women to participate in public meetings. Men are two step head of women because they receive more exposure and opportunities in education and participation. Difficult topography is another factor that keeps women from participating in consultations and decision making. Due to the difficult topography, there is a tendency of organising consultation meeting in market centres and accessible locations. In the case of hydropower project, such centres are generally far from project-affected communities. Public hearings and consultation meetings are generally conducted in the market centres and the easy locations. This has posed barriers for women and least privileged people to travel and attend such programmes.

Existing social norms, household responsibilities, mobility and social acceptances are another factors creating hindrance in women's participation in public meetings. Women are discouraged to participate community meetings. Generally, a man is considered a household head and land titles are registered in their names. By virtue of being a household head, a man is considered to be power person in decision making. Patriarchal social structure and household lead has placed man as supreme human in the family. So he is free to make family any decisions on matters concerning family and properties. Men are also ahead in participating in extra-household and community affairs. Considering the significant and two-fold impact on women and vulnerable population in infrastructure development, nation is getting late to prepare a policy that ensures women's participation in hydropower development.

(The author is a chartered accountant by profession.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

December 28, 1973

Soviet Women's Delegation Arrives

Kathmandu, Dec.27: A two-member goodwill delegation of the Soviet Women's Committee arrived here yesterday, reports RSS.

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READER'S MAIL

Ensure Timely Access To Textbooks



I am writing this in reference to the news report titled *"Government's one year: education bill in Parliament; timely access to textbooks ensured"* published on December 27, 2023 in the digital version of this daily. Certainly, education must be the utmost priority of Nepal government to ensure that the citizens are well-educated and well-informed.

Education is the basis of growth of young minds which is why it is necessary to invest in quality education. For this, the government should provide incentives and opportunities in education without discrimination in gender, age, status, class and so on. Time and again, it has been seen that textbooks aren't readily available to students in Nepal, particularly in the public education system which is languishing in comparison to private education system.

Thus, it is encouraging that the government is gearing to provide timely access to textbooks in schools. It could mean that students and teachers can work together with the help of textbooks to excel in their classes.

Gokul Bista
Baitadi

TAILPIECE

A wife went to the police station with her next-door neighbour to report that her husband was missing. The policeman asked for a description.

She said, "He's 35 years old, 6 foot 4, has dark eyes, dark wavy hair, an athletic build, weighs 185 pounds, is soft-spoken, and is good to the children."

The next-door neighbour protested, "Your husband is 5 foot 4, chubby, bald, has a big mouth, and is mean to your children."

The wife replied, "Yes, but who wants HIM back?"

+++++

A man was watching TV and enjoying a beer. "Don't go," he yelled at the screen. "Do not enter that building. Walk away. Argh, you stupid man!"

His wife called from the kitchen, "What on earth are you watching?"

"Our wedding video."

Blinken heads to Mexico for talks as migration surges at US border

AFP
Washington, Dec. 27



PHOTO: AFP
Migrants take part in a caravan towards the border with the United States in Tapachula, Chiapas State, Mexico, on December 24, 2023.

Secretary of State Antony Blinken heads Wednesday to Mexico in hopes of showing headway in tackling surging migration, which has climbed to the top of political headaches for President Joe Biden as he enters an election year.

The unusual Christmas week trip by the top US diplomat was abruptly scheduled as the rival Republican Party presses Biden for a migration crackdown in return for agreeing in Congress to one of his key priorities – support for Ukraine.

Around 10,000 people have been seeking to enter without authorization each day on the southern US border, nearly double the number before the pandemic, with a new caravan of hundreds if not thousands of people leaving by foot from southern Mexico on Sunday.

US border authorities have been so overwhelmed that they have suspended several legal crossings to focus on processing migrants.

Mexican President Andres Manuel Lopez Obrador discussed migration in a telephone call Thursday with Biden, who agreed to send Blinken, who is accompanied by Secretary of Homeland Security Alejandro Mayorkas and White House migration official Liz Sherwood.

Lopez Obrador told reporters Friday that Mexico would "reinforce our plans" to deal with US-bound migrants – few of whom are Mexicans – after his government also said it was at the breaking point on enforcement.

State Department spokesman Matthew Miller said the US delegation would speak to Lopez Obrador on the "urgent need for lawful pathways and additional enforcement actions" on migration.

Mexico, under agreements with both Biden and his predecessor Donald Trump, has agreed at least temporarily to take in migrants seeking to cross into the United States.

Trump, the frontrunner for the Republican nomination to challenge Biden in November, is again campaigning on stridently anti-immigrant rhetoric, accusing foreigners of "poisoning the blood of our country," language that critics pointed out was similar to that of Hitler. The package proposed by Biden to Congress would also fund 1,300 additional Border Patrol agents to help address migration.

The Biden administration has warned that without a deal, Ukraine will soon run out of weapons needed to repel the nearly two-year-old Russian invasion.

Andrew Rudman, director of the Mexico Institute at the Wilson Centre in Washington, expected Blinken to seek additional support from Mexico to keep migrants within its borders, such as temporary work permits.

"The Biden administration wants to show for its own domestic political reasons that they're doing everything they possibly can," he said.

"One of the challenges is that everybody wants a short-term solution to a global, longstanding problem," he said of migration. "There is no magic wand."

"Most of these people are migrating because they make a rational decision that life for them will be better in the US," he said.

Migrants have been fleeing Central American countries ravaged by poverty, violence and disasters worsened by climate change.

DR Congo's govt to ban protests against irregularities

AFP
Lubumbashi, Dec. 27



PHOTO: AFP
Congolese presidential candidate Moise Katumbi greets supporters after casting his vote at the Bwakya School polling station in Lubumbashi on December 20, 2023.

Democratic Republic of Congo's government on Tuesday is to ban an opposition protest planned for Wednesday over last week's chaotic national election as early results showed President Felix Tshisekedi in the lead.

Five opposition presidential candidates called the joint demonstration in the capital Kinshasa over alleged election irregularities.

But on Tuesday the government said it would ban the event, saying it did not have a legal basis and aimed at undermining the electoral process while the CENI election commission was still compiling results.

"No government in the world can accept this, so we will not let it happen," Vice Prime Minister Peter Kazadi told a press conference.

The protest's organisers did not immediately respond to the ban – which could exacerbate tension surrounding the Dec. 20 presidential and legislative vote that will determine whether Tshisekedi gets a second term.

Election disputes often fuel unrest in Congo and risk further destabilising Africa's second-largest country, which is a major cobalt and copper producer but is plagued by widespread poverty and insecurity in its eastern region.

After a violent campaign, the vote itself was messy, with delayed election kit deliveries, malfunctioning equipment and disorganised voting registers.

The CENI's decision to extend voting at polling stations that failed to open on election day was rejected by the protest organisers, who have also called for a full re-run of the vote.

Some independent observers also said the extension compromised the credibility of the election.

The CENI has dismissed those concerns. It started releasing results over the weekend that put Tshisekedi ahead of his 18 challengers, with 80% of around 2.8 million votes counted so far.

But the commission has not disclosed how many of the around 44 million registered voters cast their ballot, nor given any indication of what the latest given figure represents in relation to the total number of votes.

UN appoints Kaag as its Gaza humanitarian coordinator



PHOTO: AP
The Netherlands' former deputy prime minister and a Mideast expert Sigrid Kaag.

AP
United Nations, Dec. 27

Sigrid Kaag, the Netherlands' former deputy prime minister and a Mideast expert, was appointed the U.N. coordinator for humanitarian aid to war-torn Gaza, the United Nations chief announced Tuesday.

The announcement by U.N. Secretary-General Antonio Guterres follows the Security Council's adoption of a resolution on Friday requesting him to expeditiously appoint a senior humanitarian and reconstruction coordinator for Gaza, where more than 2 million civilians are in desperate need of food, water and medicine,

Guterres said Kaag, who speaks fluent Arabic and five other languages, "brings a wealth of experience in political, humanitarian and development affairs as well as in diplomacy" to her new post. She is expected to start on Jan. 8.

Gaza's entire 2.3 million population is in food crisis, with 576,000 people at catastrophic or starvation levels and the risk of famine is "increasing each day," according to a report released last Thursday by 23 U.N. and nongovernmental organizations. It blamed the widespread hunger on insufficient aid entering Gaza.

Israel stopped all deliveries of food, water, medicine and fuel into Gaza after the militant Hamas group's Oct. 7 incursion into southern Israel that killed about 1,200 people. The Israel-Hamas war has so far killed more than 20,900 people in Gaza, two-thirds of them women and children, according to the Health Ministry in Hamas-run Gaza, which doesn't differentiate between civilians and combatants among the dead.

After U.S. pressure, Israel allowed a trickle of aid in through Egypt, but U.N. agencies say that for weeks, only 10% of food needs has been entering Gaza.

Wild weather leaves at least 10 dead in Australian states

AP
Brisbane, Australia, Dec. 27



PHOTO: AP
A fallen tree lays across a camping trailer near the Gold Coast, Australia Tuesday, Dec. 26, 2023. At least nine people have died in wild weather in the Australian eastern states of Queensland and Victoria, officials said on Wednesday.

Wild weather has left at least 10 people dead in the eastern Australian states of Queensland and Victoria, officials said on Wednesday.

Three men, aged 48, 59 and 69, were killed after a boat with 11 people on board capsized in rough weather in Moreton Bay off the south Queensland coast on Tuesday, police said. Ambulances took eight survivors to a hospital in stable conditions.

The men were aboard the 39-foot pleasure craft on an annual fishing trip, The Courier Mail newspaper reported.

Queensland Police Acting Chief Superintendent Andrew Pilotto said those rescued were lucky to survive.

"The storm was still raging when they were rescued," Pilotto said. "It would have been very difficult to survive in those conditions anywhere."

Elsewhere, a 59-year-old woman was killed by a falling tree in the Queensland city of Gold Coast on Monday night. The body of a 9-year-old girl was found on Tuesday in the neighbouring city of Brisbane hours after she disappeared in a flooded storm water drain.

The bodies of a 40-year-old woman and a 46-year-old woman were found in the Mary River in the Queensland town of Gympie. They were among three women swept into the flooded river through a storm water drain on Tuesday. Another 46-year-old woman managed to save herself. Queensland Police Commissioner Katarina Carroll blamed "extraordinarily difficult weather" for the tragedies.

"It has been a very tragic 24 hours due to the weather," Carroll told reporters.

Severe weather has lashed parts of southeast Australia since Monday including Queensland and Victoria.

A woman, who is yet to be identified, was found dead late Tuesday after flash flooding receded at a campground in Buchan in regional Victoria. The body of an unidentified man, who had been camping with the woman, was found late Wednesday, police said.

Also on Tuesday, a 44-year-old man was killed by a falling branch on his rural property in Caringal in eastern Victoria. Thunderstorms and strong winds have brought down more than 1,000 power lines in parts of Queensland and left 85,000 people without electricity.

PRISM

Police remove beaver from inside hospital

Tennessee: Workers at a Tennessee hospital ended up calling for help from the police when a "huge" beaver wandered into the facility and took shelter under a piano.

The Bartlett Police Department said in a Facebook post that officers were called to St. Francis Hospital on Christmas Day when staff spotted a "huge" beaver wandering around inside. Officers arrived to find the beaver hiding under a piano in a hospital lounge. Police wrote the beaver was "probably looking to nom nom a Christmas tree."

The beaver was not injured and was returned to the wild.

World's largest Rubik's cube built in Dubai

Dubai: Dubai Knowledge Park celebrated its 20th anniversary by creating the world's largest Rubik's cube.

The park, which is home to 700 schools and other educational institutions, built a functioning puzzle cube measuring 9.8 feet on each side.

The fiberglass cube weighs in at more than 660 pounds.

Dubai Knowledge Park said on social media the cube was built to "mirror the approach to lifelong learning at Dubai Knowledge Park, where every step represents a new skill acquired, a complex task conquered and a knowledge gap filled."

(AP)

Nevada tribe says coalitions will protect sacred sites

AP
Reno, Nev., Dec. 27



PHOTO: AP
Construction continues at the Lithium Nevada Corp. mine site Thacker Pass project on April 24, 2023, near Orovada, Nev. The Reno-Sparks Indian Colony is abandoning its 3-year lawsuit aimed at blocking a lithium mine currently under construction at Thacker Pass in northwest Nevada.

The room was packed with Native American leaders from across the United States, all invited to Washington to hear from federal officials about President Joe Biden's accomplishments and new policy directives aimed at improving relationships and protecting sacred sites. Arlan Melendez was not among them.

The long-time chairman of the Reno-Sparks Indian Colony convened his own meeting 2,500 miles (4,023 kilometres) away. He wanted to show his community would find another way to fight the U.S. government's approval of a massive lithium mine at the site where more than two dozen of their Paiute and Shoshone ancestors were massacred in 1865.

Opposed by government lawyers at every legal turn, Melendez said another arduous appeal would not save sacred sites from being desecrated.

"We're not giving up the fight, but we are changing our strategy," Melendez said.

That shift for the Nevada tribe comes as Biden and other top federal officials double down on their vows to do a better job of working with Native American leaders on everything from making federal funding more accessible to incorporating tribal voices into land preservation efforts and resource management planning.

The administration also has touted more spending on infrastructure and health care across Indian Country.

Many tribes have benefited, including those who led campaigns to establish new national monuments in Utah and Arizona. In New Mexico, pueblos have succeeded in getting the Interior Department to ban new oil and natural gas development on hundreds of square miles of federal land for 20 years to protect culturally significant areas.

But the colony in Reno and others like the Tohono O'odham Nation in Arizona say promises of more cooperation ring hollow when it comes to high-stakes battles over multibillion-dollar "green energy" projects. Some tribal leaders have said consultation resulted in little more than listening sessions, with federal officials not incorporating tribal comments into the decision making.

Rather than pursue its claims in court that the federal government failed to engage in meaningful consultation regarding the lithium mine at Thacker Pass, the Reno-Sparks Indian Colony will focus on organizing a broad coalition to build public support for sacred places.

Tribal members are concerned other culturally significant areas will end up in the path of a modern day Gold Rush that has companies scouting for lithium and other materials needed to meet Biden's clean energy agenda.

Melendez was among those thrilled when Biden appointed Deb Haaland to lead the Interior Department. A member of Laguna Pueblo, Haaland is the first Native American to serve as a cabinet secretary.

Melendez, a former member of the U.S. Human Rights Commission who has led his colony for 32 years, said he understands the difficulty of navigating the electoral landscape in a western swing state where the mining industry's political clout is second only to the power wielded by casinos.

TODAY IN HISTORY

418 – A papal election begins, resulting in the election of Pope Boniface I.
457 – Majorian is acclaimed as Western Roman emperor.
484 – Alaric II succeeds his father Euric and becomes king of the Visigoths. He establishes his capital at Aire-sur-l'Adour (Southern Gaul).
893 – An earthquake destroys the city of Dvin, Armenia.
1065 – Edward the Confessor's Romanesque monastic church at Westminster Abbey is consecrated.
1885 – Indian National Congress, a political party of India, is founded in Bombay Presidency, British India.
1895 – The Lumière brothers perform for their first paying audience at the Grand Cafe in Boulevard des Capucines.
1895 – Wilhelm Röntgen publishes a paper detailing his discovery of a new type of radiation, which later will be known as x-rays.

GOVT COMMITTED FOR SOCIAL SECURITY TO SENIOR CITIZENS

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

Minister for Women, Children and Senior Citizens Surendra Raj Acharya has committed to creating an environment for all senior citizens of the country to get social security allowance.

Speaking at a programme jointly organised by Ministry and the National Senior Citizens Federation in the capital on Wednesday on the occasion of National Senior Citizens Day, Minister Acharya expressed their commitment to end the situation of depriving senior citizens of allowance for various reasons.

On the occasion of Senior Citizens' Day, Krishna Murari Gautam, a resident of Kathmandu Metropolitan Municipality-9 and Women and Old Age Service Centre in Kanchanpur District, Bhimdatta Municipality each were presented awards of Rs. 100,000.

Minister Acharya said, "In the context of growing number of senior citizens, the government has increased the allowance to the senior citizens from the point of view of social security for senior citizens."

The physical structure of the home, the public service provider, including the health service providing institutions, should be made senior citizen-friendly, as well as the environment to transfer knowledge and skill from senior citizens should be created, he said.

Gaurishankar Lal Das, former president of the Senior Citizens Federation, said that respectful treatment given to senior citizens in Nepali society has declined. Chhatra Bahadur Pradhan, President of the Federation, raising his voice for the rights of senior citizens across the country, said that the cooperation and unity of the state and all concerned stakeholders can create a senior citizen-friendly society.

On the occasion of Senior Citizens' Day, Krishna Murari Gautam, a resident of Kathmandu Metropolitan Municipality-9 and Women and Old Age Service Centre in Kanchanpur District, Bhimdatta Municipality each were presented awards of Rs. 100,000.



PHOTO: KABITA THAPA/TRN

Local businessman showing his product to a customer at his Chaku (hardened molasses) shop in Tokha Municipality of Kathmandu district.

Israel launches heavy strikes across central, southern Gaza

AP
Rafah, Gaza Strip, Dec. 27

Israel launched heavy strikes across central and southern Gaza overnight and into Wednesday after broadening its offensive against Hamas to more areas where the military had told Palestinians to seek shelter earlier in the war.

Residents reported heavy bombing in the built-up Bureij refugee camp in central Gaza, in the southern city of Khan Younis and in the southern town of Rafah, areas where tens of thousands have sought refuge as much of northern Gaza was pounded to rubble.

"It was a night of hell. We haven't seen such bombing since the start of the war," said Rami Abu Mosab, speaking from the Bureij camp, where he has been sheltering since fleeing his home in northern Gaza.

He said warplanes flew overhead and gunfire and explosions echoed from the eastern edge of the camp — which, like others in Gaza, houses refugees from the 1948 war surrounding Israel's creation and their descendants and now resembles other densely populated neighborhoods.

A home near Abu Mosab's shelter was hit, but no one was able to reach the area, he said. Mobile phone and internet service was down for several hours before being gradually restored on Wednesday, the latest of several such outages that have complicated rescue efforts.

With much of northern Gaza leveled, Palestinians fear a similar fate awaits other areas, including Khan Younis, where Israeli forces launched ground operations in early December, and a cluster of built-up refugee camps in central Gaza where the focus has shifted this week.

The military's latest evacuation orders cover an area of central Gaza that was home to nearly 90,000 people before the war and now shelters more than 61,000 displaced people, mostly from the north, according to the U.N. humanitarian office.

Israel has said the bombing campaign and ground offensive are necessary to dismantle Hamas and prevent a repeat of its Oct. 7 attack, in which militants broke through Israel's formidable defenses and killed some 1,200 people — mostly civilians — and abducted around 240. An estimated 129 remain in captivity after dozens were freed.

Achieving its goals, Israel has said, will take "many months."

Its offensive is already one of the most devastating military campaigns in recent history. More than 21,100 Palestinians, most of them women and children, have been killed, including nearly 200 people in the last 24 hours, according to the Health Ministry in Hamas-ruled Gaza.

The count doesn't differentiate between civilians and combatants.

In Khan Younis, the Palestinian Red Crescent said Israel struck a residential building next to the Al-Amal Hospital, which is run by the rescue service. Health Ministry spokesman Ashraf al-Qidra said at least 20 people were killed and dozens more wounded, with the death toll likely to rise.

Some 85% of Gaza's population of 2.3 million Palestinians have fled their homes, crowding into smaller and smaller areas in recent weeks as the ground offensive has expanded.

NC to make assessment of party's performance in government

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

A day after the coalition government consisting of the Nepali Congress completed one year in office, the Nepali Congress is likely to discuss the performance of the government and its ministers in the Central Working Committee meeting on Thursday.

The meeting is scheduled for 1.00 pm at the party central office, Sanepa, Lalitpur.

NC chief secretary Krishna Prasad Paudel informed on Wednesday that the meeting would discuss the performance of the ministers representing the NC.

"The performance of each minister inducted from the NC in the federal government will be discussed. Every minister should present their performance in the meeting. Leaders participating in the meeting can question their performance. If the meeting finds any minister performing poorly, they will be suggested to correct themselves and deliver as per people's expectations," he said.

NC is participating in the Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal Prachanda-led government under the leadership of party vice-president Purna Bahadur Khadka.

Nine ministers in the present government are from the NC.

Meanwhile, Party president Sher Bahadur Deuba on Wednesday discussed with party general secretaries Gagan Kumar Thapa and Bishwo Prakash Sharma the agenda of the meeting.

Paudel informed that current political development, the party's organisational activities and other issues would be discussed in the meeting.

Party's Mahasamiti meeting and National Assembly election are other agendas of the meeting.

The party rescheduled its Mahasamiti meeting four times, before scheduling it for February 19-22 next year.

Socialist Front repeats Nepal as its coordinator

RSS
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

The Socialist Front has decided to continue Chairperson of the CPN (Unified Socialist), Madhav Kumar Nepal, as its coordinator. The Socialist Front was formed comprising four parties--the CPN (Maoist Centre), CPN (Unified Socialist), Janata Samajbadi Party and Netra Bikram Chand-led group.

A meeting of the Front held on Wednesday at the official residence of the Prime Minister at Baluwatar, decided to give continuity to Chair Nepal to the post of Coordinator, said Vice-Chairperson of the CPN (Unified Socialist) and Front member secretary Pramesh Hamal.

Similarly, the meeting also took the decision of informing the judiciary about political agreements regarding the cases against Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda', Netra Bikram Chand 'Biplav' and Upendra Yadav.

An understanding was reached to inform the government and judiciary about the agreement reached among political parties on the issue of political cases.

The meeting also took the decision of informing the judiciary about political agreements regarding the cases against Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda', Netra Bikram Chand 'Biplav' and Upendra Yadav.

A case against Prime Minister Dahal is under consideration at the court. The Front decided to request for the implementation of political agreement and understanding made by government in different phases. Similarly, the meeting took the decision of organising interaction and various programmes in the first week and second week of the month of Magh on the occasion of Martyr's Day.

Alleged contract killer arrested in Bara: Police

BY SHIVA SHANKER MISHRA
Kalaiya, Dec. 27

Police have arrested Indian sharpshooter Sujit Kumar Singh, who is considered the contract killer in the murder of a school principal Rupesh Swarnakar in Bara.

Police had to open gunfire to arrest Singh after the police received information that he had entered Nepal receiving a contract to kill someone again.

Singh, 32, of Chhaudadano Gaun Panchayat-1 of Motihari district of Bihar, India, was taken under control by opening fire after he first opened fire at the police at Bishrampur Rural Municipality-3, Bara, on Tuesday night.

Superintendent of Police (SP) of the District Polie Office Suresh Prasad Kafle said that he had sustained a bullet injury on his right leg. Police have seized a local homemade gun along with five rounds of bullets from Singh. Other goons accompanying Singh escaped from the crime scene after the gunfire.

Singh is currently undergoing treatment at the Provincial Hospital, Kalaiya. Other details will be collected after his treatment, said police.

Police had to open gunfire to arrest Singh after the police received information that he had entered Nepal receiving a contract to kill someone again.

A preliminary police investigation has shown that Singh had earlier been involved in the murder case that happened in Kalaiya and Pacharauta, said Deputy Superintendent of Police (DSP) Dhadhi Ram Neupane.

According to the police, Singh had alleged involvement in shooting Rupesh Swarnakar alias Guddu, principal of Bal Ekta Boarding School in Kalaiya Sub-Metropolitan City-6. Swarnakar was shot dead by an unidentified shooter on October 30, 2023. Arrested Singh had also his hand in murdering Ajit Kumar Singh, an Indian national of Motihari district, India, in Pachrauta Municipality, Bara, on September 26, 2023.

Bara Police had already arrested five persons allegedly involved in the murder of Swarnakar.

Ex-Pak PM Sharif to seek 4th term in office

AP
Lahore, Pakistan, Dec. 27

Former Pakistani Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif will seek a fourth term in office, his party said Wednesday, noting he would be its consensus candidate in the upcoming parliamentary elections and the office of the prime minister.

Sharif, who has served as prime minister three times, returned to Pakistan in October after four years of self-exile in London to avoid serving prison sentences on corruption charges.

However, his conviction and sentences were overturned on appeal after his return, making him eligible to run for a seat in the parliament, which will elect the new prime minister after the Feb. 8 vote.

"There is no doubt about it. Nawaz Sharif is our candidate for the office of the prime minister," said Rana Sanaullah Khan, a senior leader in Sharif's party.

Sharif stepped down as prime minister in 2017 over the corruption charges. In July 2018, he was sentenced to 10 years in prison over purchases of luxury apartments in London. In December that year, he was sentenced to a further seven years for failing to disclose how his family set up steel mills in 1999.



PHOTO: AP

Pakistan's former Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif, center in brown coat, waves to his supporters as he leaves after a court hearing in Islamabad, Pakistan, Tuesday, Dec. 12.

Sharif's main rival, Imran Khan, is currently serving a prison term, but he too has announced plans to contest the elections. Khan was ousted in a no-confidence vote in April 2022, but he remains a leading figure and his Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf party has a large following.

PAC asks to...

although there is a provision for doing e-bidding in the tender, the authority has not been found doing e-bidding.

The Committee said that although it is a Lebanese company, the payment is being made as a Cyprus company and the destination and amount of remaining payment has not been disclosed.

The PAC has said that there is a lack of proper law and policy-level provisions to implement this system so far in Nepal.

Even the Supreme Court had directed the Authority not to take the system into implementation without introducing law. The Committee has also claimed that the whole procurement process done in the system has not been found according to the law.

Coalition...

government had succeeded in foiling such plots. Prachanda also said that the government had thwarted extremist elements trying to ignite religious tensions.

Meanwhile, the Prime Minister admitted that he had not been able to pay adequate attention to the budget preparation process this year and promised to enhance public participation while drafting the budget for the next fiscal year.

"A certain situation developed after last year's election, and I got to lead the government formed. After some time, political realities changed and I became the Prime Minister of the present coalition," he said. "By that time, the government had drafted its policies and programmes. So, we did not get to focus on the budget. This will not be the case in the next budget."

The Prime Minister was in Barpak Sulikot as part of his CPN (Maoist Centre) party's 'Maoist with People' campaign.

S. Korea sanctions N. Korea spy chief for illicit cyber activities

AFP
Seoul, Dec. 27

South Korea has sanctioned the head of North Korea's intelligence agency over illicit cyber activities following Pyongyang's recent launch of an intercontinental ballistic missile, Seoul's foreign ministry said Wednesday.

Pyongyang is already under international sanctions for its atomic bomb and ballistic missile programmes, which have seen rapid progress under North Korean leader Kim Jong Un.

The announcement came weeks after Seoul, Tokyo and Washington launched new three-way initiatives encompassing measures to address North Korea's cybercrime, cryptocurrency, and money laundering activities, which are believed to fund the country's nuclear and missile programmes.

Ri Chang Ho, the head of Pyongyang's Reconnaissance General Bureau, has been sanctioned for his involvement in "earning foreign currency through illegal cyber activities and technology theft", Seoul's foreign ministry said in a statement.

His activities have contributed to "generating revenue for the North Korean regime and procuring funds for its nuclear and missile activities", it added.

Krishi Samagri Company Limited,
Head Office, Kathmandu Nepal

Approval of Technical Bids and Opening of Price Bids

(Publication Date : December 28, 2023)

This is to inform all concerned that Krishi Samagri Company Limited has decided to open the Price bids of the following bidder for the execution of the Supply and Delivery of Chemical Fertilizer (DAP 18-46-0) - 25,000±2% MT, IFB No: KSCL/D/ICB-158/080/081 published on November 07, 2023 in "The Rising Nepal" and www.bolpatra.gov.np/egp as their bids are found substantially responsive in accordance with the Instructions to Bidders. Successful bidders are invited for their or authorized representative's presence in the following date, time and place:

Name of the bidder	Address
Commodity First DMCC	Dubai, UAE
Wilson International Trading DMCC	Dubai, UAE
Indian Potash Limited	New Delhi, India
Aditya Birla Global Trading (Singapore) Pte. Ltd.	Singapore

Price bids opening date, time and place:
Date : January 14, 2024
Time : 14:00 hours (Nepal Standard Time)
Place : Krishi Samagri Company Limited, Head Office, Kathmandu Nepal

NAFA, Siddhartha Art Foundation sign MOU for Kathmandu Triennale

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 27



A memorandum of understanding (MOU) was signed between Nepal Academy of Fine Arts (NAFA) and Siddhartha Art Foundation to host this year's 'Kathmandu Triennale' amid a programme held in Kathmandu on Wednesday.

The memorandum of understanding was signed by Devendra Kumar Kafle 'Thumkeli', member secretary of NAFA, and Sangeeta Thapa, Director of Siddhartha Art Foundation.

This partnership aims to promote the 'Kathmandu Triennale' as an art festival designed to introduce Nepali art to a global audience, foster artistic exchange between Nepali and international artists, and contribute to tourism promotion through art.

Speaking at the event, Naradamani Hartamchali, Chancellor of the Academy, expressed enthusiasm for the collaboration, emphasising the historical significance of working together in the field of Nepali art. He highlighted the programme's goal of gaining not only national recognition but also establishing an international presence.

Thapa expressed her happiness in collaborating for the upcoming 'Kathmandu Triennale' with NAFA.

She conveyed her belief that the younger generation would shape the future trajectory of Nepali art history and play a pivotal role in advancing the 'Kathmandu Triennale'.

As outlined in the memorandum of understanding, each edition of the 'Kathmandu Triennale' will feature a special exhibition showcasing the history of Nepali art and the contributions of prominent Nepali artists.

Additionally, collaborative efforts with various art campuses and organisations will help organise the Student Triennale in future. The upcoming 'Kathmandu Triennale' will be held in Kathmandu, with satellite events across Nepal.

The initiative also aims to include programmes from various genres in coordination with different organisations. During the programme, Associate Professor Sujan Chitrakar discussed the evolution of the 'Kathmandu Triennale' and its positive impact on Nepali art.

He stressed the importance of taking art from the rural areas to the international stage and promoting an art model suited to Nepal's cultural context.

Thumkeli said that the academy was going to hold the 'Kathmandu Triennale' to introduce Nepali arts to the world.

NEPAL BHASA'S 'JIGU DEY JITA YA' RELEASED

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

A Nepal Bhasa music video 'Jigu Dey Jita Ya' by Janagayak Ram Krishna was launched at a programme in Kirtipur.

Amid a programme organised by Elohan Publications on Monday, Duwal also a folk singer, was honoured with a cash award of Rs. 25,000 in the presence of Kirtipur Municipality former Mayor Ramesh Maharjan, Kirtipur Municipality-8 Ward Chair Sanu Maiya Maharjan, lawmaker Sailendra Bajracharya and others. Additionally, a special Page 3 edition featuring Duwal and Lunaakha (Nepal Bhasa magazine) including literature of Duwal was made public.

Singer Rani Shova Maharjan lent her voice to the song with the music composed by Jeevit Jalmi. The song featuring actress Hisila Maharjan was directed by Darshan Bir Shakya.

'Shared Horizons' on display at Classic Art Gallery



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

A group art exhibition titled 'Shared Horizons' by 12 Nepali artists and four Thai artists is currently on display at Classic Art Gallery in Lalitpur.

The art exhibition, which was inaugurated on December 12, will continue until December 30.

Classic Art Gallery, in collaboration with Kalashala, had conducted a day workshop between the Nepali and Thai artists.

The exhibition features artworks created during the day workshop, as informed by Sarita Dangol of Classic Art Gallery. In the exhibition, 42 works of art, including paintings, sculptures and ceramic art are on display.

Artworks of Kunti Magar, Kripol Kittisirot, Anamika Gautam, Basan Sittiket, Bindo Pradhan, Sanjeet Maharjan, Mukesh Shrestha, Suchin Shrestha, Nilesh Shakya, Sudikshya Dangol, Santa Maharjan, Natsuree Techawiriyataweesin, Sushila Singh, Jaruwan Mueanjkhwa, Suraj Silpakar, and Sujan Dangol have been put on display.

Lee Sun-kyun of Oscar-winning film 'Parasite' is found dead

AP
South Korea, Dec. 27



Lee Sun-kyun, a popular South Korean actor best known for his role in the Oscar-winning movie "Parasite," was found dead in a car in Seoul on Wednesday, authorities said, after weeks of an intense police investigation into his alleged drug use.

Police and emergency officers initially found Lee in what they believed was an unconscious state in the car parked on a street in northern Seoul. Emergency officers later confirmed he was dead, according to Seoul's Seongbuk police station.

Police had been searching for Lee, 48, after receiving a report that he was missing, Seongbuk police said.

They refused to provide further details including whether they had determined Lee killed himself. But South Korean media outlets including Yonhap news agency said that Lee's family earlier Wednesday reported to police that he left home after leaving a message similar to a suicide note.

Lee's body was later transported to a nearby Seoul hospital, according to Seongbuk police.

Lee appeared in "Parasite," which won Oscars for best picture and three other categories in 2020. The class satire was the first non-English-language film to win best picture in the then-92-year history of the Academy Awards, and was the first South Korean movie to win an Oscar. In the film, Lee played the head of a wealthy family.

The film's cast, including Lee, also won a Screen Actors Guild award for the best motion picture ensemble cast in 2020. He was nominated for best actor at the International Emmy Awards for his performance in the sci-fi thriller "Dr. Brain" last year, as well.

Even before "Parasite," Lee had been a popular actor in South Korea for a long time. He rose to stardom for his role in a hit TV drama series, "Coffee Prince (2007)," and gained mainstream popularity with the medical drama "Behind The White Tower (2007)," "Pasta (2010)" and "My Mister (2018)."

Lee had undergone police probes into allegations that he used illegal drugs at the residence of a bar hostess. Lee filed a suit against two people including the hostess, alleging they blackmailed him. The investigation prompted extensive tabloid coverage. Lee insisted he was tricked into taking the drugs and that he did not know what he was taking, according to Yonhap.

The rapper Ye issues an apology in Hebrew

AP
Los Angeles, Dec. 27



The rapper formerly known as Kanye West, who has a long history of making antisemitic comments, apologised to the Jewish community in an Instagram post written in Hebrew on Tuesday.

"I sincerely apologize to the Jewish community for any unintended outburst caused by my words or actions," Ye wrote.

"It was not my intention to offend or demean, and I deeply regret any pain I may have caused," continued the rapper, who legally changed his name to Ye in 2021.

The statement arrives less than two weeks after Ye went on an antisemitic rant in Las Vegas while promoting his upcoming album "Vultures," due out Jan. 12. In the rant, he made insidious insinuations about Jewish influence and compared himself to Jesus Christ and Adolf Hitler.

"After causing untold damage by using his vast influence and platform to poison countless minds with vicious antisemitism and hate, an apology in Hebrew may be the first step on a long journey towards making amends to the Jewish community and all those who he has hurt," the Anti-Defamation League said in a statement to The Associated Press and other news outlets on Tuesday. "Ultimately, actions will speak louder than words but this initial act of contrition is welcome."

The American Jewish Committee, however, criticized Ye's use of Hebrew in the apology.

"Beyond being bizarre and possibly a ploy to gain more attention, the Hebrew apology — posted without translation — is inaccessible to most American Jews who do not speak the language," the AJC said in a statement to the AP. "To be sure, using Hebrew to communicate with the Jewish community intentionally denies most American Jews— and, consequently, non-Jews—the ability to directly see Kanye's apology."

"While he claims that he is committed to learning and greater understanding, this apology speaks to 'any pain I may have caused,' rather than acknowledging the pain that he has caused," the AJC continued.

Ye has a history of offensive and antisemitic comments, including repeated praise of Hitler and the Nazis. He also once suggested slavery was a choice and called the coronavirus vaccine "the mark of the beast." In October 2022, he was criticized for wearing a "White Lives Matter" T-shirt at his Paris Fashion Week show and tweeted that he was going to go "death con 3 on JEWISH PEOPLE," an apparent reference to the U.S. defense readiness condition scale, DEFCON.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: It's impossible to know where you're heading. There's a complicated square between your sign's ruler Mars in your adventurous 9th house and Neptune in your sleepy 12th house, which could turn all your energy.

Taurus: Everyone is in an easy-going mood -- everyone except you, that is. You're prone to extremes while blazing Mars burns through your 8th House of Secrets.

Gemini: Someone else pushing you doesn't mean you need to move at the moment. A peer could be exerting pressure on you as energizer Mars stimulates your relationship sector.

Cancer: The thrill of adventure isn't enough to stand in the way of your immediate responsibilities. You've got a lot to accomplish while action planet Mars marches through your can-do 6th house!

Leo: You've rarely met a spotlight you didn't enjoy, but even the boldest Lion might get stage fright at this time. Mars is in your 5th House of Fame, emboldening your talents and calling you out to center stage.

Virgo: Someone may leave you high and dry when you least expect it. Your emotions are stronger than usual as heated Mars moves through your sensitive 4th house, plus, someone could fail to empathize with you when Mars squares Neptune in your partnership sector.

Libra: The hottest flames can still burn out. It's easy to start fires active Mars smolders in your busy 3rd house, but its square to Neptune in your health sector could result in you exerting more energy than you have at your disposal.

Scorpio: Being productive is not currently a fun experience. You're probably in an industrious frame of mind as Mars powers through your 2nd House of Salary, encouraging you to get to work. Even so, that drive may evaporate when Mars squares Neptune in your 5th House of Pleasure.

Sagittarius: Understanding your feelings isn't presently a simple thing. You've got lots of passion and fire while Mars tours your sign, but it's making an uncomfortable square to mysterious Neptune in your emotional sector.

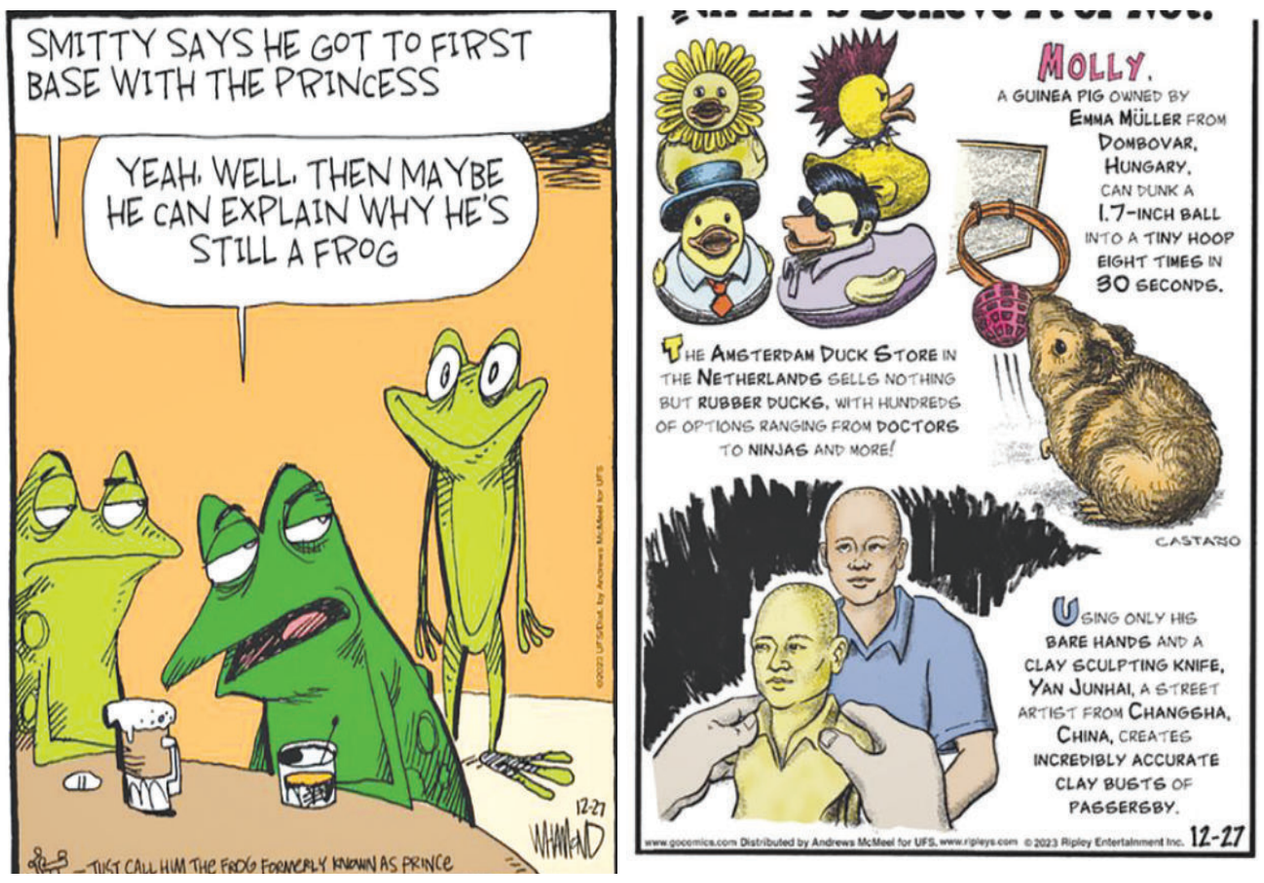
Capricorn: Life may feel more like a maze than your usual reality. There is a baffling square between energizer Mars in your hidden 12th house and foggy Neptune in your distracting 3rd house, making it impossible to know which way to gos.

Aquarius: Good intentions can currently be less than good for your bank account. Carefree budgeting could sound just fine, due to the square between outspoken Mars in your outgoing 11th house and dreamy Neptune.

Pisces: Your ambitions are burning brightly one minute -- the next, they fizzle right out. This bouncing back and forth is due to a square between Mars in your 10th House of Career and spiritual Neptune in your own sign.

CARTOON

gocomics.com



APF advance to playoff



PHOTO: BIKASH/TRN
Helisha Gurung of Bagmati Province taking run against Lumbini Province during Prime Minister Cup women's T20 National Cricket Tournament at TU Cricket Ground, Kirtipur, Wednesday.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

The Armed Police Force (APF) Club registered fifth consecutive victory to advance to the playoffs at the ongoing PM Cup Women's T20 National Cricket Tournament on Wednesday. Koshi Province and Sudurpashchim Province have both achieved their fourth win, while Bagmati Province has secured its third win to keep its hope of entering the playoffs alive.

APF managed to set a massive target of 161 against Karnali, with Rajmati Airee and Mamta Chaudhary both scoring half-centuries for the team. Airee scored 67 runs off 55 balls, while Chaudhary hit 62 runs off 55 balls.

APF's bowling side performed well, winning the match by 92 runs at the TU Cricket Stadium. Karuna Bhandari took four wickets by giving 13 runs, and Suman Bist took two wickets for seven runs to restrict Karnali to 68/8 in 20 overs. APF leads the table with 10 points.

On the other hand, Koshi won the match against Gandaki by 55 runs. Koshi's bowlers defended a low target of 104 as they bowled out Gandaki's batsmen at 48 runs in 15 overs. Rubina Chhetry took three wickets and gave no runs to Gandaki. She was supported by Alisha Khadiya, who gave nine runs and took two wickets. Koshi trails APF in second place with eight points.

Sudurpashchim won the match against Madhes by five wickets in the Upper Mulpani Cricket Stadium. Sudurpashchim, who was given a target of 83, scored 86 in the loss of five wickets with only a ball of the 20-over game remaining. Despite having eight points, Sudurpaschim follows Koshi in third position, being inferior in net run rate.

Bagmati emerged victorious in the match against Lumbini by nine runs. Lumbini was unable to reach the target of 110 as the players could only score 100 at a loss of eight wickets in 20 overs. Helisha Gurung of Bagmati was the highest scorer in the match with 46 runs off 45 balls. With three wins in a row, Bagmati sits in fourth spot with six points. Lumbini is in fifth place with four points. With back-to-back three defeats, Gandaki is in sixth place with two points. Madhes also has two points and sits in seventh place, while Karnali occupies the bottom place, losing five matches in a row.

Koshi, Madhes, Gandaki and Karnali will face Sudurpashchim, Lumbini, APF, and Bagmati on Thursday.

Liverpool go top, Man United fightback to beat Villa

AFP
London, Dec. 27

Liverpool climbed to the top of the Premier League as Darwin Nunez ended his goal drought to inspire a 2-0 win against Burnley, while Rasmus Hojlund broke his own barren run to cap Manchester United's thrilling fightback to beat Aston Villa 3-2 on Tuesday.

Jurgen Klopp's Liverpool took an early lead through Nunez at Turf Moor and held on despite wasting a host of chances. Nunez's eighth goal this season was his first for 12 games since he netted against Bournemouth in the League Cup on November 1.

Diogo Jota, back from a month's injury absence, wrapped up the victory late on to leave Liverpool two points above second placed Arsenal, who have a game in hand. Arsenal can regain top spot with a victory at home to West Ham on Thursday.

After successive draws with Manchester United and Arsenal prior to Christmas, this was an essential victory for Liverpool's title ambitions.

On Liverpool being in pole position, Klopp said: "That's nice. It will probably change and that's no problem. It was not perfect but we are where we are."

At Old Trafford, United were in danger of another damaging defeat when goals from John McGinn and Leander Dendoncker put Villa in control by halftime at Old Trafford.

Erik ten Hag's team were booed off at the interval but they staged a much-needed revival, sparked by Alejandro Garnacho scoring their first goal in seven hours and twenty minutes.

Garnacho struck again to equalise before Hojlund finally scored his first Premier League goal, in his 15th appearance, with eight minutes left.

Hojlund's cathartic strike ended United's four-match winless run in all competitions and lifted them to sixth in the Premier League. "At half-time I said to the team, 'keep believing'. The atmosphere changed a lot from the first half to the second. If we play our best we can beat anyone," Ten Hag said.

Two games without a win have dented Villa's unexpected title challenge.

Unai Emery's men remain third, three points behind Liverpool after their first defeat in 11 matches in all competitions. Chris Wood's hat-trick against his old club Newcastle gave Nuno Espirito Santo his first victory as Nottingham Forest boss, a 3-1 success at St James' Park.

Wood left Newcastle to join Forest in June, but had scored only four times for his new club. Alexander Isak's first half penalty put Newcastle ahead before New Zealand striker Wood equalised late in the first half.

Wood struck twice more in the second half to hand former Tottenham manager Nuno his maiden victory with Forest in his second game in charge after replacing the sacked Steve Cooper.

It was Forest's first win in eight games and only their second success in their last 15 matches.

Luton boss Rob Edwards said South Yorkshire Police are investigating an alleged racist comment towards Carlton Morris in his side's 3-2 win at fellow strugglers Sheffield United.

Fulham boss Marco Silva insisted his goalkeeper Bernd Leno "touched" but "didn't push" a ball boy during the Cottagers' 3-0 defeat at Bournemouth.

The second-half incident occurred when Leno went to collect the ball from the youngster's outstretched hand before using his own hand to make deliberate contact with the shoulder of the boy, who appeared to take a step back for balance.



PHOTO:AP
Manchester United's Alejandro Garnacho, second left, celebrates after scoring his side's first goal during the English Premier League soccer match against Aston Villa in England.

TITLE HOLDER DINESH ADVANCE TO QUARTER-FINALS

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

Defending champion Dinesh Prajapati, top-seeded Bhuvan Nagarkoti, Rame Magar, Bhuwan Kumar Rokka, Rabi Khadka, Sanjay Lama, Jayram Shrestha and Pradip 1Kumar Lama advanced to the quarter-finals of the Surya Nepal NPGA Match Play at the Royal Nepal Golf Club on Wednesday.

Dinesh Prajapati defeated Toran Bikram Shahi on the final hole of the second event under the Surya Nepal Golf Tour 2023-24, while No 2 pro Bhuvan beat Ram Krishna Shrestha 5&4. No 9 Bhuwan Kumar Rokka defeated No 8 Dhana Bahadur Thapa on the final hole.

Fourth-seeded Jayram Shrestha was the biggest winner of the day as he outplayed No. 13 Deepak Magar 7&6. No. 5 Sanjay Lama beat No. 12 Shivaram Poudel 5&3, while No. 6 Rabi Khadka outplayed No. 11 Ramesh Adhikari 3&2. Likewise, No. 7 Rame Magar defeated No. 10 Surya Prasad Sharma 4&3 and No. 15 Pradip Kumar Lama upset second-seeded Niraj Tamang on the final hole.

On Thursday, Bhuvan Nagarkoti will play against Bhuwan Kumar Rokka; Jayram will take on Sanjay; Rabi will face Dinesh; and Rame will take on Pradip in the quarter-final matches. The semi-final matches will also be played on Thursday.

Australia take control of second Test

AFP
Melbourne, Dec. 27

Pat Cummins and Nathan Lyon put Australia in the driving seat of the second Test at the Melbourne Cricket Ground on Wednesday to leave Pakistan tottering at 194-6, still 124 runs behind on day two.

At stumps, Mohammad Rizwan was on 29 and Aamer Jamal not out two after Cummins took the crucial wickets of Abdullah Shafique (62) and Babar Azam (one), then Agha Salman (five).

Lyon chipped in by removing Imam-ul-Haq (10) and Shan Masood (54), while Josh Hazlewood bowled Saud Shakeel for nine as Pakistan's dream of a first Test win in Australia since 1995 faded.

The visitors had claimed seven wickets in the morning session on a pitch offering seam and swing, restricting the hosts to 318.

Aamer Jamal spearheaded Pakistan's charge with 3-64 after Australia resumed on 187-3 after being sent into bat, with Marnus Labuschagne top-scoring on 63.

Openers Haq and Shafique made a positive start in reply, surviving a series of loud appeals.

But veteran spinner Lyon, fresh from taking his 500th wicket during the first Test in Perth, finally earned a reward when Haq edged to Labuschagne at slip.

Undeterred, Pakistan upped the run rate after tea with Masood hitting Lyon for six and Shafique reaching his first Test 50 in Australia, and fifth overall, with a four off Mitchell Starc.

But their 90-run partnership was broken by Cummins, who showed sharp reflexes to stick out his left hand for a catch off his own bowling to end Shafique's stay.

Fired up, he then clean bowled danger man Azam before Lyon returned to claim his second wicket when Masood miscued and Mitchell Marsh did well to hold a catch with the sun in his eyes.

Hazlewood took care of Shakeel before Cummins brought himself back and accounted for Salman, caught by wicketkeeper Alex Carey to leave Pakistan in trouble.

Jamal strikes

Labuschagne had been a rock on day one, digging in for an overnight 44 off 120 balls.

He padded up again alongside Travis Head on nine with the sun shining, smacking a boundary off Shaheen Shah Afridi in the opening over to signal Australia's intent.

The explosive Head drove Hasan Ali to the ropes off his first ball and followed it up with another in the same over to quickly get in the groove.

But his flair cost him on 17, lashing at a wide Afridi delivery that took a thick edge and was well collected by Salman in the slips.

At the other end, Labuschagne kept plugging away to bring up his 17th Test half-century.

Marsh was given out twice in successive balls during a fiery Ali over while on seven by West Indian umpire Joel Wilson. He reviewed both decisions -- for lbw and caught behind -- and survived.

But just as the match appeared to be slipping away from Pakistan, Jamal bagged the wicket of Labuschagne, who edged to Shafique at slip.

Carey and Starc quickly followed as Pakistan cashed in with a new ball, before Marsh holed out to Jamal off Mir Hamza on 41 and the tail folded.

Australia won the first Test of the three-match series in Perth by 360 runs.



PHOTO: AP
Australia's Pat Cummins celebrates taking the wicket of Pakistan's Agha Salman during the second day of their cricket test match in Melbourne, Wednesday.

WEATHER

Thursday

Sunrise at 6:53 am, Sunset at 5:17 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Thursday)

Partly cloudy in the hilly areas of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province and mainly fair in rest of the country.

Expected Temp.: 18-20 Rain Probability: 0%

Wednesday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	16.7	5.3	0.0
Dipayal	25.2	7.3	0.0
Dhangadi	26.1	10.0	0.0
Birendranagar	24.0	7.5	0.0
Nepalgunj	26.0	12.2	0.0
Jumla	17.7	-3.7	0.0
Ghorahi	23.6	10.0	0.0
Pokhara	22.7	10.5	0.0
Bhairahawa	26.6	10.7	0.0
Simara	27.2	11.5	0.0
Kathmandu	19.4	7.8	0.0
Okhaldhunga	19.6	8.8	0.0
Taplejung	17.6	6.6	0.0
Dhankuta	23.9	10.4	0.0
Biratnagar	27.4	12.6	0.0
Jomsom	11.0	-5.0	0.0*
Dharan	26.8	14.5	0.0*
Lumle	17.0	7.2	0.0*
Janakpur	30.5	12.6	0.0*
Jiri	16.4	2.7	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

December 28, 2023

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates
For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 133.06	Rs. 133.66
Euro	1	Rs. 147.08	Rs. 147.75
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 169.40	Rs. 170.16
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 156.03	Rs. 156.73
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 91.01	Rs. 91.42
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 100.81	Rs. 101.27
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 100.64	Rs.101.10
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.33	Rs. 9.37
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.61	Rs. 18.70
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.48	Rs. 35.64
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.49	Rs. 36.66
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.87	Rs. 3.88
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.23	Rs. 36.39
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.74	Rs. 28.87
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.28	Rs. 10.33
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 13.34	Rs. 13.40
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.73	Rs. 19.82
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 17.04	Rs. 17.12
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 432.91	Rs. 434.86
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.93	Rs. 354.52

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

Bangladesh claim historic victory over NZ in first T20

AFP
Napier, Dec. 27

Bangladesh claimed an historic five-wicket win over New Zealand on Wednesday after their bowlers ran riot in the opening game of their three-match Twenty20 series on Wednesday in Napier.

This was Bangladesh's first Twenty20 win on New Zealand soil, four days after also claiming a maiden away one-day international win over the Black Caps in Napier.

"I'm really excited and very proud of how we played," said Bangladesh captain Najmul Hossain Shanto. Asked to bat by Shanto, New Zealand made a disastrous start losing three wickets before reaching 134 for nine after their 20 overs.

"Our bowlers learnt quickly in these conditions with the new ball," Shanto added. "We were really confident after we restricted them."

The Black Caps bowlers gave home fans hope with the early wickets of Bangladesh opener Rony Talukdar and Shanto.

Veteran Litton Das partnered up with Soumya Sarkar, then Towhid Hridoy to steer Bangladesh to 96-4 after 13 overs. The visitors were wobbling at 97-5 as they lost wickets in quick succession after Afif Hossain was caught for one run off six balls.

Das, who finished on 42 not out, survived two close calls as he battled cramp.

The on-field umpire gave him out lbw on Tim Southee's bowling, but the Bangladesh opener stayed at the crease when the review showed the ball would have sailed over the stumps.

Ish Sodhi then caught Das at the boundary, but stepped onto the boundary rope to give away six runs.

It fell to allrounder Mahedi Hasan, who finished 19 not out, to hit the winning runs in his partnership of 40 alongside Das with eight balls spare.

"Credit to Bangladesh, they bowled well," said Mitchell Santner, who captained New Zealand with regular white ball skipper Kane Williamson rested.

"We fought hard with the ball to make it interesting, but the powerplay took it away from us with the bat," Santner added.

The second and third Twenty20 in Internationals will both be played at Mount Maunganui on Friday, then Sunday.

Bangladesh, ranked ninth in Twenty20 international cricket, punched above their weight to floor third-ranked New Zealand.

Having dismissed the Black Caps for 98 in Saturday's third one-day international in losing the series 2-1, the Bangladesh bowlers picked up where they left off.

Hasan bowled Tim Seifert in the opening over.

Shoriful Islam was the pick of the Bangladesh bowlers with 3-26, including having Finn Allen caught and Glenn Phillips trapped lbw in consecutive balls.

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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

PRESIDENT STRESSES DEVELOPMENT OF TOURISM

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Baglung, Dec. 27

President Ramchandra Paudel has said that the people's living standards should be raised by developing the tourism sector.

Speaking at the inauguration programme of the 7th Baglung Festival here on Wednesday, the President said, "We have beautiful natural tourist spots. The rural economy can be developed by bringing in tourists by building infrastructure and promoting touristic attractions with joint government and private sector initiatives."

President Paudel recalled the hard struggle days spent in Baglung during his political life and said that he has the responsibility to protect the achievements of people's sacrifices.

"No one can harm this constitution written by the people of Nepal," he said.

President Paudel expressed his belief that the festival would play an important role in the economic, social and cultural development and prosperity of the area around Baglung, which is rich in natural resources including the Dhaulagiri snow range and the fertile land.

The capital and experience of the private sector are needed for the development of this sector, he said, "The activation of the private sector is necessary to promote tourism while protecting and reviving rural life, special natural places, beautiful rural terrain, livelihood and ethnic costumes."

President Paudel said that the steps taken by businessmen for tourism promotion and development were exemplary.

He requested the private sector to increase investment as the development and prosperity of the region could be achieved by developing cultural, religious, sports and adventure tourism products.

"The government alone is not in a position to achieve economic development by transforming the agricultural sector and expanding industrial businesses to increase production and create jobs, promote exports and replace imports, make the economy self-sufficient and eliminate absolute poverty. This is only possible if the government partners with the private sector," said the President.

He said that the development and prosperity of Gandaki province would be possible only if the construction of Kaligandaki Corridor and Mid-Hill Highway was completed and Pokhara Airport and Korala Pass were made fully operational.

Speaking on the occasion, Chandra Prasad Dhakal, President of the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry, requested the complete and speedy operation of the development and tourism infrastructure of Gandaki province. Since Gandaki Province is physically connected to two big neighbours, India and China, and has many unique tourist areas like Pokhara, Manang, Mustang, Kaligandaki and Himalayas to Dhorpatan in Baglung, more efforts should be made to benefit from this, he suggested.

"India and China have a population of over 3 billion. Having a big tourism market nearby is a big opportunity. Therefore, the provincial government should pay attention to the fact that the construction of tourism infrastructure in this area can attract more tourists by air and land," said Dhakal.



PHOTO: RSS

A view of Ne-Pemasal, the base camp of Jugal mountain range of Sindhupalchowk district.

Health sector makes notable improvements

BY PALLAV BHUSAL
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

The government led by Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' is making notable improvements in major health sector indicators.

The Health Ministry has demonstrated its primary commitment to strengthening healthcare services at both local and national levels. The ministry has passed dozens of pending strategic medical action plans including on sexual violence and mental health and financial strategies.

According to Dr. Prakash Budathoki, spokesperson for the Ministry of Health and Population, it has asked health workers to return to their designated workplace. "Health Minister Mohan Bahadur Basnet has said that many health workers were taking deputation (kaaj) and are not working at their work location, mainly in rural areas. We have recognised nearly 800 health workers working outside their designated location and asked them to return for service," added Budathoki.

Similarly, Budathoki informed that the government has sent around 500 health workers who studied under government scholarships to rural areas for services.

"Another major development the government has ushered is the introduction of telemedicine services. Under this service, senior doctors residing in the urban areas can consult with doctors and patients in the rural areas through internet and telephone services," he said.

Use of this advance technology will help in the O.P.D. registration system

> The ministry has passed dozens of pending strategic medical action plans including on sexual violence and mental health and financial strategies.

One Year of Government

and an electronic healthcare record, improving overall service for the patients, he added.

The World Health Organisation has recently presented a report saying that Nepal needs nearly 92,100 healthcare workers for the smooth operation of the health sector across the country.

"Currently, we have around 30,000 manpower delivering services in the health sector. This year the ministry has asked the local, provincial and central government to work together and come up with the required number of manpower to hire medical workers," said Budathoki.

The government plans to add another 30,000 health workers to boost health services across the country.

"The health ministry is working with the Education Ministry and Nepal Medical Education Commission to amend the medical education act to give opportunities to young people who desire to study medical subjects within the country," added Budathoki.

The government has provided free medical services to economically disadvantaged citizens and elderly people.

"There are around 3,000 beds across the country providing free services to financially disadvantaged groups and elderly people. We have also asked private hospitals to allocate 10 per cent beds for economically disadvantaged citizens," informed Budathoki.

The government has also constituted a committee to effectively implement insurance packages for health services.

Budathoki informed that the government has decided to start joint payment system which includes paying a 10 per cent service fee for expensive services and medicines. "We have started this policy so as to discourage the tendency of only taking advantage of the insurance system. This will help identify real economically disadvantaged citizens and these groups of people will not have to pay the 10 per cent fees to avail of medical services," he said.

All levels of government have come together to plan a fee structure in the health sector to ease and reduce the cost of medical treatment of Nepali citizens.

Likewise, the government has already completed the construction of 26 basic hospitals as a part of building hospitals at all local levels.

"The government has already allocated budget and plans to complete the construction of 100 basic hospitals this year. But, the local levels are providing health services by leasing buildings and operating hospitals," said Budathoki.

With the establishment of federalism, the government has made many improvements and fulfilled commitments in the health sector. With a rising population and lack of adequate manpower the government is continuously working to provide health services across the country by recognising problems and solving them quickly.

PM's address follow-up

Melamchi project working to supply water at earliest

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has assured that the government will bring the water of the Melamchi Water Supply Project (MWSP) to Kathmandu within next 28 days.

In his televised address to the nation on Tuesday, PM Prachanda stated, "I am working with a comprehensive plan to supply 170 million liters of water daily to the Kathmandu Valley within next 28 days."

Expressing empathy for the unfulfilled dream of the Kathmandu Valley residents to access water from the Project, he reassured that the narrative suggesting that the Melamchi Water Supply Project's water would not be supplied to Kathmandu would be proven wrong. He said that discussions on the second phase of the Melamchi Project were in progress, and a high priority would be given to the structural reform of the agencies related to water supply.

The work is progressing according to the PM's address, said Padam Kunwar, Senior Divisional Engineer at Melamchi Water Supply Board. "We are currently at Ambathan, extracting water from a small tunnel to assess its condition," he said. The tunnel was filled with water during the rainy season. Ambathan's tunnel is one of the tunnels connecting to the main tunnel at the Melamchi headworks.

"There are three gates, and there is no issue with Gate No. 1. We are currently addressing the issues with Gate No. 2, and work on Gate No. 9 within the headworks will commence on Friday," Kunwar explained.

Currently, six excavators, 10 tippers, eight to 10 engineers, and 10 labourers are mobilized in the field. When the work on Gate No. 9 begins, additional human resources and equipment will be deployed, Kunwar informed.

The work is going on under the specified insurance coverage and is expected to be completed ahead of the scheduled time frame, he mentioned.

Earlier, on December 19, the Ministry of Water Supply and the contracted company Sino Hydro signed a memorandum of understanding to facilitate the supply of Melamchi water to the Valley within next 28 days.

The meeting, chaired by Secretary at the Ministry Suresh Acharya, resolved to ensure the supply of Melamchi water to every household in Kathmandu within the specified timeframe, provided there was no emergency. The agreement was also made to mobilise resources immediately for the construction and clearance work.

The water will be processed by Kathmandu Upatyaka Khanepani Limited (KUKL) at Sundarijal Water Treatment Plant and redistributed to households in the Kathmandu Valley.

The Melamchi water supply was halted due to monsoon rains from June 23, 2023.

Coalition govt will last five years: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 27



Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the government of the present coalition parties will last for five years.

Speaking at a public interaction programme organised in Barpak Sulikot Rural Municipality-8, Gorkha, on Wednesday, Prime Minister Prachanda said that the government had made some records in its first year in office and said that many more good things would be done in the next four years.

He said, "In the past year, the government addressed the issues of citizenship and usury, made strides in social security and development, and led mountain countries to demand climate justice. If this much work can be done in one year, we can rest assured that much more will be done in the next four years."

Despite the government's many achievements, the Prime Minister said that anti-change and anti-republic forces would never acknowledge them. So, he requested the people and pro-transformation entities to promote the good that has been done.

"We have ensured proportional representation for all, including women and Dalits, and have taken Singha Durbar to the villages. We have to speak in favour of the positive changes that have occurred.

Conspirators are inaccurately trying to show the country as immersed in darkness, he said, stressing that the

» SEE PAGE 6

PAC asks to stop purchase of telecom monitoring system

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

The Public Accounts Committee (PAC) under the House of Representatives has directed the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology (MoCIT) and Nepal Telecommunication Authority (NTA) to stop purchasing of the Telecommunication Traffic Monitoring and Fraud Control System (TERAMOCS) and its establishment.

A meeting of the PAC chaired by Rishikesh Pokharel held on Wednesday directed the anti-graft body, Commission for Investigation of Abuse of Authority (CIAA), to study and begin the legal process of the procurement process adopted in TERAMOCS.

The Committee has also instructed the CIAA to update on the progress report of the study of the technology's procurement process in every 30 days to the Committee.

The direction of the Committee came after holding a meeting with the officials of the NTA, Nepal Telecom and other officials on Wednesday at Singha Durbar.

The Committee has raised 15 questions in regard to the need for the purchase of the technology and has also instructed to decide on purchasing and its implementation in 'as it is' condition.

In addition, the Committee has been instructed to conduct a thorough analysis of the work done so far in purchasing the system.

Chairman Rishikesh Pokharel said that the Authority has been instructed to submit the progress report every 30 days and if it is found that the authority has misused authority in its purchase, directed to begin the legal charge process according to the law.

The members of the PAC have raised questions regarding its tender process. It has been said that the expert of JAS Group's Sainath Naidu has been given the responsibility to prepare the draft of the tender process, and later, JAS Group's Naidu presented himself as representative of SJA Holding of Switzerland to get the tender in their favour. "It seems that the tender has been accepted despite a conflict of interest," according to the direction of the PAC.

The PAC has also claimed that

» SEE PAGE 6

Selfiekali crowned most beautiful elephant

BY BASANTA PARAJULI
Sauraha, Dec. 27

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Dr. Bijay Shrestha, the judge for the contest and a veterinarian at Chitwan National Park, said, "Identifying the beauty of an elephant is a challenging task. However, based on the criteria set by the judges, Selfiekali was crowned with the title this year."

He said that the primary goals of the competitions were to enhance the bond between elephants and humans and to attract tourists.

Selfiekali, a 17-year-old, won the title and a cash prize of Rs. 15,000 by surpassing seven other contestants.

Similarly, an 11-year-old Rimjhimkali of Chitwan National Park became the 1st runner-up while Sambridikali of Ram Prasad Rijal became the 2nd runner-up. They won cash prizes of Rs. 10,000 and Rs. 5,000 respectively.



PHOTO: BASANTA PRAJULI/TRN

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Sauraha, a tourist town, has been organising the Elephant Beauty Contest including the Elephant Festival.

Thapaliya said, "Such events deliver a message that elephants could be used in various ways for tourism promotion, not just for jungle safaris."

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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL

PRESIDENT STRESSES DEVELOPMENT OF TOURISM

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Baglung, Dec. 27

President Ramchandra Paudel has said that the people's living standards should be raised by developing the tourism sector.

Speaking at the inauguration programme of the 7th Baglung Festival here on Wednesday, the President said, "We have beautiful natural tourist spots. The rural economy can be developed by bringing in tourists by building infrastructure and promoting touristic attractions with joint government and private sector initiatives."

President Paudel recalled the hard struggle days spent in Baglung during his political life and said that he has the responsibility to protect the achievements of people's sacrifices.

"No one can harm this constitution written by the people of Nepal," he said.

President Paudel expressed his belief that the festival would play an important role in the economic, social and cultural development and prosperity of the area around Baglung, which is rich in natural resources including the Dhaulagiri snow range and the fertile land.

The capital and experience of the private sector are needed for the development of this sector, he said, "The activation of the private sector is necessary to promote tourism while protecting and reviving rural life, special natural places, beautiful rural terrain, livelihood and ethnic costumes."

President Paudel said that the steps taken by businessmen for tourism promotion and development were exemplary.

He requested the private sector to increase investment as the development and prosperity of the region could be achieved by developing cultural, religious, sports and adventure tourism products.

"The government alone is not in a position to achieve economic development by transforming the agricultural sector and expanding industrial businesses to increase production and create jobs, promote exports and replace imports, make the economy self-sufficient and eliminate absolute poverty. This is only possible if the government partners with the private sector," said the President.

He said that the development and prosperity of Gandaki province would be possible only if the construction of Kaligandaki Corridor and Mid-Hill Highway was completed and Pokhara Airport and Korala Pass were made fully operational.

Speaking on the occasion, Chandra Prasad Dhakal, President of the Federation of Nepalese Chambers of Commerce and Industry, requested the complete and speedy operation of the development and tourism infrastructure of Gandaki province. Since Gandaki Province is physically connected to two big neighbours, India and China, and has many unique tourist areas like Pokhara, Manang, Mustang, Kaligandaki and Himalayas to Dhorpatan in Baglung, more efforts should be made to benefit from this, he suggested.

"India and China have a population of over 3 billion. Having a big tourism market nearby is a big opportunity. Therefore, the provincial government should pay attention to the fact that the construction of tourism infrastructure in this area can attract more tourists by air and land," said Dhakal.



PHOTO: RSS

A view of Ne-Pemasal, the base camp of Jugal mountain range of Sindhupalchowk district.

Health sector makes notable improvements

BY PALLAV BHUSAL
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

The government led by Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' is making notable improvements in major health sector indicators.

The Health Ministry has demonstrated its primary commitment to strengthening healthcare services at both local and national levels. The ministry has passed dozens of pending strategic medical action plans including on sexual violence and mental health and financial strategies.

According to Dr. Prakash Budathoki, spokesperson for the Ministry of Health and Population, it has asked health workers to return to their designated workplace. "Health Minister Mohan Bahadur Basnet has said that many health workers were taking deputation (kaaj) and are not working at their work location, mainly in rural areas. We have recognised nearly 800 health workers working outside their designated location and asked them to return for service," added Budathoki.

Similarly, Budathoki informed that the government has sent around 500 health workers who studied under government scholarships to rural areas for services.

"Another major development the government has ushered is the introduction of telemedicine services. Under this service, senior doctors residing in the urban areas can consult with doctors and patients in the rural areas through internet and telephone services," he said.

Use of this advance technology will help in the O.P.D. registration system

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One Year of Government

and an electronic healthcare record, improving overall service for the patients, he added.

The World Health Organisation has recently presented a report saying that Nepal needs nearly 92,100 healthcare workers for the smooth operation of the health sector across the country.

"Currently, we have around 30,000 manpower delivering services in the health sector. This year the ministry has asked the local, provincial and central government to work together and come up with the required number of manpower to hire medical workers," said Budathoki.

The government plans to add another 30,000 health workers to boost health services across the country.

"The health ministry is working with the Education Ministry and Nepal Medical Education Commission to amend the medical education act to give opportunities to young people who desire to study medical subjects within the country," added Budathoki.

The government has provided free medical services to economically disadvantaged citizens and elderly people.

"There are around 3,000 beds across the country providing free services to financially disadvantaged groups and elderly people. We have also asked private hospitals to allocate 10 per cent beds for economically disadvantaged citizens," informed Budathoki.

The government has also constituted a committee to effectively implement insurance packages for health services.

Budathoki informed that the government has decided to start joint payment system which includes paying a 10 per cent service fee for expensive services and medicines. "We have started this policy so as to discourage the tendency of only taking advantage of the insurance system. This will help identify real economically disadvantaged citizens and these groups of people will not have to pay the 10 per cent fees to avail of medical services," he said.

All levels of government have come together to plan a fee structure in the health sector to ease and reduce the cost of medical treatment of Nepali citizens.

Likewise, the government has already completed the construction of 26 basic hospitals as a part of building hospitals at all local levels.

"The government has already allocated budget and plans to complete the construction of 100 basic hospitals this year. But, the local levels are providing health services by leasing buildings and operating hospitals," said Budathoki.

With the establishment of federalism, the government has made many improvements and fulfilled commitments in the health sector. With a rising population and lack of adequate manpower the government is continuously working to provide health services across the country by recognising problems and solving them quickly.

PM's address follow-up

Melamchi project working to supply water at earliest

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has assured that the government will bring the water of the Melamchi Water Supply Project (MWSP) to Kathmandu within next 28 days.

In his televised address to the nation on Tuesday, PM Prachanda stated, "I am working with a comprehensive plan to supply 170 million liters of water daily to the Kathmandu Valley within next 28 days."

Expressing empathy for the unfulfilled dream of the Kathmandu Valley residents to access water from the Project, he reassured that the narrative suggesting that the Melamchi Water Supply Project's water would not be supplied to Kathmandu would be proven wrong. He said that discussions on the second phase of the Melamchi Project were in progress, and a high priority would be given to the structural reform of the agencies related to water supply.

The work is progressing according to the PM's address, said Padam Kunwar, Senior Divisional Engineer at Melamchi Water Supply Board. "We are currently at Ambathan, extracting water from a small tunnel to assess its condition," he said. The tunnel was filled with water during the rainy season. Ambathan's tunnel is one of the tunnels connecting to the main tunnel at the Melamchi headworks.

"There are three gates, and there is no issue with Gate No. 1. We are currently addressing the issues with Gate No. 2, and work on Gate No. 9 within the headworks will commence on Friday," Kunwar explained.

Currently, six excavators, 10 tippers, eight to 10 engineers, and 10 labourers are mobilized in the field. When the work on Gate No. 9 begins, additional human resources and equipment will be deployed, Kunwar informed.

The work is going on under the specified insurance coverage and is expected to be completed ahead of the scheduled time frame, he mentioned.

Earlier, on December 19, the Ministry of Water Supply and the contracted company Sino Hydro signed a memorandum of understanding to facilitate the supply of Melamchi water to the Valley within next 28 days.

The meeting, chaired by Secretary at the Ministry Suresh Acharya, resolved to ensure the supply of Melamchi water to every household in Kathmandu within the specified timeframe, provided there was no emergency. The agreement was also made to mobilise resources immediately for the construction and clearance work.

The water will be processed by Kathmandu Upatyaka Khanepani Limited (KUKL) at Sundarijal Water Treatment Plant and redistributed to households in the Kathmandu Valley.

The Melamchi water supply was halted due to monsoon rains from June 23, 2023.

Coalition govt will last five years: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 27



Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' has said that the government of the present coalition parties will last for five years.

Speaking at a public interaction programme organised in Barpak Sulikot Rural Municipality-8, Gorkha, on Wednesday, Prime Minister Prachanda said that the government had made some records in its first year in office and said that many more good things would be done in the next four years.

He said, "In the past year, the government addressed the issues of citizenship and usury, made strides in social security and development, and led mountain countries to demand climate justice. If this much work can be done in one year, we can rest assured that much more will be done in the next four years."

Despite the government's many achievements, the Prime Minister said that anti-change and anti-republic forces would never acknowledge them. So, he requested the people and pro-transformation entities to promote the good that has been done.

"We have ensured proportional representation for all, including women and Dalits, and have taken Singha Durbar to the villages. We have to speak in favour of the positive changes that have occurred.

Conspirators are inaccurately trying to show the country as immersed in darkness, he said, stressing that the

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PAC asks to stop purchase of telecom monitoring system

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Dec. 27

The Public Accounts Committee (PAC) under the House of Representatives has directed the Ministry of Communication and Information Technology (MoCIT) and Nepal Telecommunication Authority (NTA) to stop purchasing of the Telecommunication Traffic Monitoring and Fraud Control System (TERAMOCS) and its establishment.

A meeting of the PAC chaired by Rishikesh Pokharel held on Wednesday directed the anti-graft body, Commission for Investigation of Abuse of Authority (CIAA), to study and begin the legal process of the procurement process adopted in TERAMOCS.

The Committee has also instructed the CIAA to update on the progress report of the study of the technology's procurement process in every 30 days to the Committee.

The direction of the Committee came after holding a meeting with the officials of the NTA, Nepal Telecom and other officials on Wednesday at Singha Durbar.

The Committee has raised 15 questions in regard to the need for the purchase of the technology and has also instructed to decide on purchasing and its implementation in 'as it is' condition.

In addition, the Committee has been instructed to conduct a thorough analysis of the work done so far in purchasing the system.

Chairman Rishikesh Pokharel said that the Authority has been instructed to submit the progress report every 30 days and if it is found that the authority has misused authority in its purchase, directed to begin the legal charge process according to the law.

The members of the PAC have raised questions regarding its tender process. It has been said that the expert of JAS Group's Sainath Naidu has been given the responsibility to prepare the draft of the tender process, and later, JAS Group's Naidu presented himself as representative of SJA Holding of Switzerland to get the tender in their favour. "It seems that the tender has been accepted despite a conflict of interest," according to the direction of the PAC.

The PAC has also claimed that

» SEE PAGE 6

Selfiekali crowned most beautiful elephant

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